

satisfied merely to maintain a steady complement. Scarcely a day passes, but he receives new requests for employment; however, he makes it a rule to insist upon proper qualifications—*i.e.*, *wounds received in battle, and not testimonials of good conduct*. These are his very own words (2nd May 1817).

In the spring of this current year, the peasants of Apulia were direly oppressed by famine; so the leader of the *banditti* made it his business to distribute among the starving victims a series of regular ration-vouchers, which the more prosperous citizens were obliged to honour. This ration consisted of a pound and a half of bread for a man, one pound for a woman and two pounds for a woman with child. The woman who had first aroused my curiosity had been receiving six two-pound vouchers a week for the past month.

Moreover, no one can ever discover where the *indipendenti* have their current headquarters. All the spies are on their side. In Roman times, such a brigand would have been a Marcellus.

NAPLES, 16th June. Returning from my Calabrian excursion, I found myself subjected to a certain number of vexations; I learned later that the authorities were 'uneasy' about me, while I, for my part, was decidedly 'uneasy' lest I be expelled from Naples. No other travellers, be they from Sweden, Saxony or England, need live in fear of such a threat; but neither are they welcomed with open arms by every person of distinction in the land, upon no other credentials than the fact of being *French* and *unprotected by the Embassy*. A certain noble and generous citizen, whose name I shall never forget nor ever pronounce, offered to find me sanctuary within his own house. Yet he had met me but five or six times in all, and was himself in no little disfavour with the authorities. This is the kind of incident from which the strongest bonds of attachment towards a country may be born. In Bologna, I have five or six acquaintance to whom I might have turned with such a request; but then Bologna never knew those two years of tyranny and murder

from 1799 to 1801. If divers police-officials *should* resolve to make my life a misery, they could have, let me protest, none but the flimsiest grounds for doing so; granted that there may be a grain or two of contempt in my attitude towards themselves; yet even supposing that I were to cherish theoretical approval for this or that stratagem aimed at their discomfiture, I should none the less be of an opinion that, in this tricky century of ours, subversive activities are strangely liable to be found out; and further that, in case of failure, the wounded pride of *Patriotic Sentiment* could hardly fail to attribute the root and cause of all the evil to the presence of an *interfering foreigner*.

However, leaving this aside, I have nothing but unqualified admiration for the Neapolitan patriots. Naples may boast the eloquence of Mirabeau and the bravery of Desaix. I am privately convinced, beyond all doubt, that this country is destined to achieve its parliamentary constitution before 1840. However, since the gulf which separates a man of the merit of signor Tocco from the primaeval brutality of the populace is so immeasurably wide, the enlightened classes will of necessity see their schemes founder more than once upon the rocks, before they succeed in bestowing upon their native land the gift of liberty. Consider the antiquated manners still prevailing in *i promessi Sposi*, a novel by signor Manzoni.

19th June. Today, strolling along the *largo di Castello*, hard by that most curious theatre built in a cellar underground, where, by entering at street-level, you may discover yourself directly among the seats of the gallery, I bought myself a book. My purchase was entitled: *della Superiorità in ogni cosa del Sesso amabilissimo . . . etc.*, 1504. Anyone who has given a moment's passing study to the social history of women will remember that it was François I who first invited them to Court in 1515. Previously, every baron's castle had maintained the appearance of a tyrant's stronghold, wherein friendship had no place, but

only slavish obedience: even she who was wife unto her Lord enjoyed no higher consideration than that of a slave, over whom her master might exercise the powers of life and death. She might be stabbed and killed: such accidents would pass for the lawful chastisement of broken vows. In some circumstances, the dagger-stroke would reflect the sudden wrath of a savage, ever jealous to assert his own moral superiority; in others, the death of the *châtelaine* might be requisite in order that her Lord might take unto himself another, whose favours were withheld until he should acknowledge her his wife. At the gallant courts of François I and Henri II, women began to prove *useful* to their husbands in the art of intrigue;¹ consequently their status rose rapidly towards equality, and ever more nearly so, as the fear of God began to lose the place of honour it had hitherto occupied in the heart of mankind. Yet in France during the sixteenth century women were still no better than domestic servants; whereas in Italy, one of the themes most constantly treated by those writers who, at the time, rode highest on the crest of fashion, was precisely the *Superiority of the Amiable Sex over that of Man*. The Italians, being more easily swayed towards the tender passions, having a lesser degree of coarseness in their nature, being less enamoured of physical prowess, less warlike and less feudal, were fully prepared to acknowledge this general principle.

The notions which women carried in their minds being in no way culled from books—since, in those far-off, fortunate

¹ Consider, in the library of monseigneur le duc d'Orléans, that most singular *Collection of Airs*, that were sung by the Maids of Honour to Queen Catherine de Medicis. Each volume, magnificently chased and bound with clasps of silver, bears in printed letters the name of the noble damsel whose office it was to sing such ballads. Their monstrous indecency is proof plain and incontrovertible of the utter falsity of the portrait of the manners of the age which may be discovered in *la Princesse de Clèves*. The *Mémoires de madame la duchesse d'Orléans*, mother of the Regent, are evidence that, even at the Court of Louis XIV, morals were cruder and coarser than those which reign today in 1826, in the household of the dreariest little calico cloth-maker; in compensation, however, there was infinitely greater wit. [1826]

days, they read but little—but rather founded upon the true and ascertainable nature of things, this reign of equality between the sexes introduced a phenomenal mass of plain and unpretentious *sense* into Italian heads. I could name a hundred principles of conduct, which elsewhere still call for proof and demonstration, yet which, in Rome, are taken as axiomatic. If ever women were to be admitted to a status of perfect equality, this would be the surest hallmark of *civilisation*; it would double the intellectual resources of the human race and proportionately multiply its eventual chances of happiness. Women are much closer to true equality in the United States of America than they are in England. In America, they are entitled by law to privileges which, in France, are granted to them only by favour of a sophisticated social tradition, or else for fear of ridicule. In any little English provincial township, the shopkeeper who takes two hundred pounds a year across his counter is in no lesser degree master of his wife than of his horse; whereas, among the merchants of Italy, a woman may enjoy consideration, liberty and happiness, one and all in exact proportion to her beauty. In Rome, a city where all *power* goes hand in hand with *celibacy*, you may chance to enter a shop and enquire after an engraving of Michelangelo's *Prophet Daniel*: 'Good sir, we have it—that I know; but it means searching through all the portfolios; would it trouble you to call again, when my husband is at home?' Here you have a new excess, the very opposite of that which prevails in England. Perfect equality, which must prove a source of happiness for both sexes alike, may be attained only upon one condition: namely, that the privilege of the *duel* should be extended to the other sex. And why not? The pistol calls for *skill*, not strength. In the ideal society, any woman, by voluntarily constituting herself prisoner for the term of two years, may, at the expiry of this statutory period, be granted a divorce. Such notions as these, in the year 2000 A.D. or thereabouts, will no longer seem fantastical*.

25th June. I heard today a jewel of repartee, which is the nine-days' wonder of the whole of Naples; unhappily, I cannot relate it here; perhaps, in any case, it would lose its savour in Paris. Everyone in France knows the story of the mother of many daughters, one of whom lay dying. In the frenzy of grief which seized her, the distracted mother called out: 'Dear God! Leave me *this* my daughter, and take unto Thyself all the others!' At which one of her sons-in-law, being present in the chamber, approached her, saying: 'Madam, are your daughters' husbands to be considered as one flesh and indivisible with your daughters in this matter?' This remark sent all those present into a fit of laughter, not excluding the dying girl.

This is a typical example of Gallic humour; the point is beautifully made. Yet, notwithstanding the solemnity of the hour, there is a manifest intent to please; the temptation to be amusing was well-nigh irresistible, nor was it resisted. In Italy, however, this same remark would have fired an outburst of indignation. The epigram, in Italy, is neither *light* nor *amusing*: rather is it pregnant with a boundless wealth of significance, as indeed among the Ancients. There was once a Florentine statesman, whose genius alone propped up the flagging strength of the republic, which, in that time, was threatened by the direst calamities. And in these circumstances, it fell out that an envoy must be found to fill an embassy of the utmost importance. Whereupon the Florentine cried out: *S' io vo, chi sta? S' io sto, chi va?* Among all the peoples of this modern era, none bears a closer resemblance to the Ancients than the people of Italy. Indeed, many customs and traditions may be observed, which have survived from an epoch *before* the Roman conquest. Compared with ourselves, Italy has received but a tolerably mild inoculation of feudalism; nor has she been grievously tainted with that sentiment which is the chief preoccupation of contemporary nations—indeed, their true and only religion—the false, monarchic cult of *honour*, which is a curious amalgam

of *vanity* and *virtue* (that which is useful to the greatest number).

Some years ago it so befell that the most revered of scholars from the learned world of Paris was visiting the city of Naples. At that time, there was much discussion in polite society touching a certain Etruscan vase, of colossal dimensions and of wondrous craftsmanship, that Prince Pignatelli had recently acquired by purchase. Our scholar, in the company of a certain Neapolitan gentleman, called to see the vase; but as it chanced, the Prince was absent from home, and it was an aged manservant who introduced the curious visitors into a low-ceilinged apartment, where, placed reverently upon a pedestal of wood, they discovered the ancient urn. The French antiquarian examined it minutely, admiring above all the exquisite subtlety of the design and the flowing elegance of the forms; and after a while, having taken out his note-book, he resolved to try and make copies of two or three groups of figures. For full three-quarters of an hour he stood there, plunged in a trance of admiration; eventually, however, he withdrew, not forgetting as he took his leave, to give the manservant an extremely generous tip. 'If Their Excellencies would be pleased to call again tomorrow, before the hour of noon', observed the retainer amid the profusion of his gratitude, 'the Prince himself will be at home, and Their Excellencies will be able to view the original.' In truth, the object which our scholar had so ecstatically been admiring was nothing but a copy made by some local craftsman. The *savant* begged his Neapolitan companion to say nothing of this misadventure, which, next day, was the talk of all the town. Were I so minded, I might even reveal the name of this illustrious man of learning*; for there are not a few persons who had direct acquaintance with the incident alive in Paris at the moment. Indeed, had I a truly malicious bent, I might quote further the 'discovery' (attributed to a Most Illustrious Personage*) of the pedestal of the famous *Column of Phocas* in Rome, which in point of fact already had been unearthed in the year 1811 in course of the programme of

restoration set afoot by the *Comptroller of Crown Property* in the city. But let us rather leave such anxious vanities in peace.

While I am on the subject of Etruscan vases, genuine or otherwise, I should mention that, being in Naples, I visited the *Museo degli Studj*, and saw the private collection which had once belonged to madame Murat. As soon as a vase shows traces of competent design, you may rest assured that it is a modern counterfeit . . . dear God! the *lies* that are published daily in the press! Some two years since, the Museum received an allocation of a thousand ducats to provide show-cases for the vases of this particular collection; to date, however, the Curator has managed to lay hands on no more than six hundred ducats of his allocation. The *abate* Taddei, of course, publishes this figure with a due number of noughts appended. Yet even so scrupulous a citizen as the *abate* Taddei *might* be lying . . . might he not? It is inexcusable of me, not to have mentioned earlier the draped figure of *Aristides* at the *Museo degli Studj*; but curiosity leads fatally to emotional exhaustion; and when finally the poor tourist returns to his lodgings, he is *dead*!

This *Aristides**, a truly admirable piece of sculpture, is an example of the revolt against idealism in art, like the bust of Vitellius which may be seen at Genoa. The hero has suspicions of a stomach; moreover, he is draped. Into the bargain, the poor fellow was so thoroughly roasted by the red-hot lava of Herculaneum that his original marble is scarcely more than lime; he would crumble to dust at a touch. The statue is placed high up on a plinth. Now it was a recognised sport, among certain English tourists, after they had been well dined, to take a good run at the plinth, jump, and land on the top of it; yet the least slip in this exercise could have meant a hand placed on the statue to steady a failing balance . . . and there would have lain poor *Aristides*, all in powder. I learned later that this was a problem which much exercised the ingenuity of the Curators: for how should so delicate a matter of anxiety

be broached in seemly fashion? Finally, someone had the happy inspiration to enquire at what hour these English gentlemen were wont to dine. Investigation revealed the fact that they were never drunk before two o'clock in the afternoon; consequently, the *Museo degli Studj* now shuts at two instead of four. I have fully satisfied myself of the truth of this curious circumstance; several keepers have shown me the edge of the plinth, some three foot off the ground, damaged by the impact of boots.

2nd July. It was chance, this morning, which led me into the society of don Nardo*, the most distinguished lawyer in Naples; as I was waiting in his antechamber, I observed a monstrous beeves'-horn, ten foot high if it was an inch, sticking perpendicularly out of the floor, like a gigantic nail. I can only suppose that it must have been put together out of three or four horns from less fabulous animals. Its purpose is to act as a sort of *lightning-conductor* against the *jettatura*—that is, against the 'evil eye'. 'I am perfectly well aware', said don Nardo, as I took my leave, 'of the absurdity of this superstition; yet what would you, all the same? Every lawyer is bound to make himself a pack of enemies; and so I find this object comforting.'

If there is one thing more fantastic still than this, it is surely the fact that there are people who actually believe that they possess the power to *cast* such spells. The Duke of Bisagno*—that *Great Poet*—was one day walking down the street. A peasant chanced to cross his path, bearing upon his head a large basket of strawberries. At the instant of meeting, the basket fell to the ground, and the strawberries began to roll about among the cobbles. The Duke, in great concern, ran over to the peasant: 'Good friend', he said, 'I swear to you I never looked at you!'

I was making a few irreverent remarks this very evening about the *jettatura* to a man of quite outstanding intellectual

powers. 'Did you never read that book about the *jettatura* by Niccolò Volitta?' he enquired. 'Caesar, Cicero, Virgil . . . they all believed in it. Are such as these so greatly inferior in wisdom to ourselves?' Gradually, to my indescribable astonishment, it began to dawn upon me that this friend of mine *himself* believed in the *jettatura*. In fact, he presented me with a miniature beeves'-horn made of coral, which I now wear on my watch-chain. Whenever I find myself in fear of the evil eye, I am to twist it round and round between my fingers, taking care to point the sharp end in the direction of my enemy.

There was a merchant, a skeleton of a man with handsome, slightly Jewish eyes, who was recently come to Naples. Soon after his arrival, the Prince of *** invited him to dinner. Now, one of the Prince's sons saw fit to ask a certain *marchese* to sit beside our merchant at the table; and, when the meal was over, enquired of him:

'Well, and what did you make of your neighbour?'

'I?' asked the *marchese*, sorely puzzled. 'Why, nothing in particular.'

'I merely asked', said the Prince's son, 'because there are rumours that he is a bit of a *jettatore*.'

'Ah!' cried the *marchese*, growing pale upon the instant. 'What a disgraceful trick to play on me! But why couldn't you have warned me a moment earlier? I would have thrown my cup of coffee in his face!'

The secret consists in *breaking the column of air* which unites the eye of the necromancer to the object upon which it rests. This desired result may be obtained by throwing a quantity of liquid, although a gunshot is considered more effective still. It is by virtue of this same power of the *jettatura* that snakes and toads, merely by gazing fixedly at a bird singing away on the topmost branch of a tree, can cause it to fall from bough to bough, and so eventually to drop into the jaws of its waiting enemy. Take one large-sized toad and throw him into a jar filled with spirits of wine, where he will die, but with his eyes

open. Now if, within the space of four-and-twenty hours following the creature's demise you look into these eyes, then the *jettatura* will be cast upon you, and you will fall to the ground in a dead faint. I offered to try out the experiment on myself, and was told for my pains that I was an *unbeliever*.

Here is a factual instance (*anno domini* 1824). Don Jo*, Curator of the Museum at P***, and moreover a man of considerable attainments, suffers from the imputation of being a *jettatore*. It was his longstanding desire to be granted an audience by the late King Ferdinand of Naples—an audience which this monarch, as may well be imagined, was a good deal more than loath to grant. At last, however, after some eight years of petitioning, the King yielded to the solicitations of don Jo's friends at Court, and agreed to receive the Curator of his own Royal Museum. The audience lasted some twenty minutes, during which time, from beginning to end, His Majesty was desperately ill at ease, incessantly manipulating between his fingers a miniature beeves'-horn made of coral. The following night, he was struck down by apoplexy.

I was told once, walking along the cliff-top at Dover, that a person of nervous temperament, standing on the very brink of a precipice, feels an irresistible temptation to jump into the abyss.

Belief in the *jettatura* is no less prevalent in Norway than in Naples. High praise for Francesco I, King of the Two Sicilies.

15th July. *Soirée* held by signora Tarchi-Sandrini at Portici. An enchanting drawing-room, not ten paces from the sea; between ourselves and the water, nothing but a little grove of orange-trees. Gentle lapping of the waves on the beach; view of Ischia across the bay; exquisite ices. I reached the house rather too early; consequently, witnessed the arrival of ten or a dozen women who appeared to be selected from among the most distinguished company of Naples. Signora Melfi has recently

spent three years abroad, having followed her husband into exile; each year, she would pass the winter months in Paris; now she has returned, escorted by some twenty or thirty travelling-chests stuffed with the latest French fashions. Tonight, she soon found herself the centre of a ring of attentive listeners: 'A handsome young man', she was saying, 'and of the very best family, whispered this secret into my ear in Paris: *Since I ceased to dance, I find society less intolerably boring. The irksome weariness of inviting one's hostess to take the floor, of reserving a chair for sitting out, of manoeuvring for a partner—such vexing trifles would set my nerves on edge for a whole evening!*' How striking and how true a portrait of the web of civilisation in Paris: all genuine pleasure choked to death by the stifling restrictions of formality which society chooses to impose upon it.

'Whenever one of my acquaintance comes to call upon me', pursued signora Melfi, 'I can sense instantly whether his visit is dictated by *policy*, or whether simply by *brio*—in other words, because the notion chanced to jump into his head at the very instant when he was passing in the neighbourhood of my *palazzo*. Apparently this distinction—so vital, in all conscience—remains wholly invisible to those ladies who keep open house in Paris; no visitor ever crosses the threshold, save his presence is dictated by plan or policy. Formal visits, formal costume . . . behold the consequences of *severity!*'

'In England, education makes every man his neighbour's equal; the scion of a noble house has no resource, if he would set a distinction between himself and the son of plain Mr Coutts, save *affectation*. This unbecoming vice is shortly destined to overtake yourselves in France, for all that your asinine *liberal politicians* are so firmly persuaded that democratic government can breed naught but virtue and high-mindedness. I was saying one day to one of my more intimate acquaintance in Paris: *What a pretty sight, to be sure, are these boulevards of yours; and what extraordinary faces one may observe there!*

'Yes indeed, she replied, with an imperceptible echo of

the schoolma'am in her voice, *but of course it is not done to go walking there.*

'This remark was more than I could properly endure. *It is not done, I burst out, when what is done is done in imitation of someone else's doing. But you, my dear, are a daughter of a Peer of the Realm of France; you were born to the enjoyment of a splendid fortune; in you, therefore, I look to find that dauntless pride which imitates no one. If you are not the cynosure of the world, who then shall take your place? Some upstart creature with neither right nor title, save her own impertinence!*

'Dare one imagine, in days gone by, that the dashing duc de Bassompierre would have been concerned with the "slur" which might befall his noble reputation from walking in this direction rather than in that? To tell the truth, I seem to detect a touch of *parvenu* susceptibility about these modern proprieties. Bassompierre, faced with the doctrine that *it was not done to go walking on the boulevard*, would most assuredly have retorted: *I, sir, shall go where I please; and myself shall ennoble that place where I am!* It is fear of ridicule—*fear*, that ugliest of emotions—which steals away the youth of half the younger generation in Paris.

'I myself have seen a young man refuse to show himself at a concert—an admirable entertainment, given by all that was most fashionable in the operatic world that season, and in the programme of which, by a minor miracle, there was not a single thing of boredom—for no better reason than that he would be obliged to *be seen in company with all those appalling shopkeepers' wives from the rue Saint-Denis*. The very day following, I spoke to him: *Never dare pay your addresses to me again; in my eyes, you are ridiculous!* Queen Marie-Antoinette would drive out in a hired cab whenever the fancy took her; in those days', continued signora Melfi, turning on me, 'back in 1786, you used to know the meaning of laughter, and you had not yet learned to sell your souls. But six months ago, whenever I entered a drawing-room, and there discovered

some two score gentlemen assembled, all from the very best families, I would say to myself: *Full six-and-thirty of those here present have sold their souls and consciences—or else are busy looking for a buyer. And these, these gentry, have the effrontery to sneer at us Italians and call us vile!* How admirable, how gentle and refined, is the tenor of life in Paris! The domestic *cat*, which, in London, is such a savage, spiteful brute, is a civilised and amiable creature when you meet her in the shops of Paris—a fact which speaks volumes in praise of your shop-girls. The mild and equable temper of the average Parisian *dog* is no less eloquent in respect of the *men* who are its masters.

‘And what a fantastic deal of trouble you take to teach your sons the secrets of vanity, before you are so much as four years old! What affectation in their little dresses! In France, not twenty years from now, the *outward seeming* will have usurped the whole man. Already you are beginning to feel the harsh and frosty touch of *formality*: I foresee with deep dismay that you are destined to become as drab and melancholy as the English; even the simple act of blowing your nose will leave you constantly in *apprehension*, lest you be failing in some imperious *duty*.

‘That above all which I admire in your *Jacobins* of the old stock, was precisely that they had minds above such trivialities; indeed, it was in order to uproot such unworthy preoccupations from the hearts of the younger generation that they invented the deliberately careless costume of a Marat. But your young men today appear forty before they are twenty. One might be led to suspect that they find all women hateful; their ambition, to judge by what they seem, lies towards the founding of a new religion. Similarly, I have the impression that your women, in the very flower of youth, experience a strange distaste for men: all of which would seem to herald a merry decade or so ahead!’

Signora B*** declared one day*: ‘Music is incapable of portraying that sense of spiritual *aridity* which is the primary

source of the prevailing atmosphere of *boredom* surrounding a Court. The only effective remedy for this distemper is *opera seria*, treated in the manner of Metastasio. The genius of Metastasio, no less than the music to which his words are set, endows the very cruellest of tyrants with feeling, and even with a touch of generosity. The courtier enjoys *opera seria*, because he is delighted that the public should be afforded a glimpse of his calling, seen in its most favourable light.'

'When first I arrived in Paris', asserted signora Melfi, 'one thing struck me most forcibly: whenever I was at a ball, I observed that *apprehension* caused the fingers of all the dancers to twitch convulsively. Never was there a sign, within a thousand miles, of those spontaneous high-spirits which are the natural prerogative of youth, nor even of simple enjoyment.'

'The irony of the situation', added Colonel T[ecco], 'is this: in French society, every individual consents to be a victim, in the hope that eventually others may lie at *his* mercy; for, after all, why else should a man abase himself before the fear of ridicule? Is ridicule a Minister of State, awarding honours, stars and decorations, and allotting pensions on the Civil List?'

'Nothing on earth', said don Francesco, 'is such anathema to the fashionable world of Paris as *energy*. This hatred hides its features behind a hundred different masks; none the less, you may rest assured that its presence is always felt, secretly dictating every movement of the heart.

'Energy may lead to unforeseeable situations; and in such emergencies, the man whose whole stock-in-trade is *vanity* may find himself left floundering. O shame unspeakable!'

'On one occasion', resumed signora Melfi, 'I was invited to make up a picnic excursion to the Spa at Enghien. One of the guests—a man of some intelligence, moreover—being piqued by jealousy, took a strange, perverted joy in deliberately throwing cold water over all the ingenious conversation and high spirits of his neighbours. Now that is something which we

language—for all that I never understood two words together of this particular brogue. Two hours of intense delight: I fell into conversation with my nearest neighbours, extravagant partisans of Napoleon; they commented on various changes: judges, they said, were beginning no longer to demand bribes as a matter of course; out of ten robberies, one at least would be punished, etc., etc.

The final curtain fell at midnight; by one o'clock, we had already taken once more to the highroad. The Austrians have established watch-pickets every mile or so along the route; the local highwaymen are baffled, furious and half-dead of starvation.

NAPLES, 9th February. Grandiose approach to the city: for the space of an hour, we dropped down towards the sea, following a broad highway carved out of the same soft rock upon which Naples itself is built: thickness of the ramparts; first building—*l'Albergo de' Poveri**; deeply impressive—no comparison with that over-rated bit of sham baroque, that chocolate-box effect that Rome is pleased to call the *Porta del Popolo*.

And so here we are at last, snugly established in the *Palazzo degli Studj*; step out of the door, turn left, and there before you lies the *via di Toledo*—one of the principal goals of all my journey, the busiest, most joyous thoroughfare in the entire universe. Yet would you believe it? For five mortal hours we trudged from inn to inn, vainly imploring shelter; there must be fully two or three thousand English tourists in the place; and when finally I ferreted out a lodging, it proved to be an eyrie perched up seven flights of stairs. Yet, for all its disadvantages, it faces the *San-Carlo*, and I can look out over Vesuvius and the sea.

Tonight, however, the doors of the *San-Carlo* remained implacably shut; instead, we set off hot-foot for the *teatro dei Fiorentini*, which is a tiny theatre in the form of an elongated

horse-shoe, ideal for music—not unlike the *Salle Louvois* in Paris. Here, as in Rome, each ticket bears a number; all the first rows, I was told, were fully booked. The programme includes *Paolo e Virginia*, a popular opera by Guglielmi. By offering double, I managed to secure a seat in the second row. The auditorium was a glittering sight; every box was taken, crowded with women radiant in their finery; for here, unlike at *la Scala*, the whole well of the theatre is illuminated by a central chandelier.

Overture: complex, elaborate stuff, thirty or forty different themes in discordant juxtaposition, all too cramped for the listening ear to grasp, too crowded to awaken the slumbering sensibilities; an arduous, arid and wearisome piece of work, leaving the mind already surfeited with notes before the curtain rises.

Whereupon we behold *Paul* and *Virginia*, played by Margherita Chabran and Graciata Canonici; the latter, a simpering little minx, as *Paul*. The lovers have lost their way in the forest (same initial situation as in the French version of the opera)—a circumstance which calls imperiously for a duet. A duet we shall have, then, steeped in elegance and affectation. Enter the honest *Domingo*—in other words, Casaccia, the famous Casaccia, the idol of Naples much as Potier is the idol of Paris. His language is the dialect of the people; he is a veritable hippopotamus of a man, moreover—a circumstance which allows him to indulge in the broadest of farcical *lazzi*. For instance, being seated, he would resolve to cross his legs so as to seem more truly at his ease; the spirit was willing, but alas! the flesh was all too weak; straining in a final monstrous effort, he would overbalance upon his nearest neighbour, and send the whole assembly toppling headlong: general collapse (*cf.* the novels of Pigault-Lebrun). This actor, popularly known as Casacciello, is treated by the public like a demi-god; he intones his recitative through his nose, like some old capuchin Friar. (Here, at the *Fiorentini*, everyone sings with a sort of

nasal drone.) But the repertoire of his antics soon struck me as repetitive; by the end, I was finding him less and less amusing. We from the North are fastidious, not easily satisfied by this southern sense of humour; our laughter is harder to release.

At all events, *Domingo-Casacciello* proceeds to guide the errant lovers back to the log-cabin. Now Virginia has a father, sung by Pellegrini, a first-rate *basso profondo*, whose rank in the Neapolitan hierarchy corresponds to that of Martin in our own: both actors command the same astonishing vocal flexibility, marred by the same frigidity of temperament. I have always found him extremely effective in arias which make no powerful call on the emotions. He is a mightily handsome fellow, by all Italian standards, with a great jutting nose and a fine black beard; the tally of his conquests (so I am told) is considerable; all I know for sure is that he is remarkably attractive.

The part of the *Ship's Captain* (tenor) was sung by a good-looking but disenchantingly wooden young man from Venezia Giulia, in which Province he is reported to have risen under Napoleon to the rank of *sous-préfet**. Signorina Chabran has a tolerable voice, but her interpretation was still more wooden and expressionless than that of la Canonici or Pellegrini; I found her infinitely less pleasing to watch than la Fabre, the little Milanese soprano whose strained and weary features seem sometimes to betray a hint of feeling. All in all, a passable performance, well-adapted to meet the tastes of the common-or-garden run of theatre-goers; yet not a note to appeal to the heart of him whose ambition it is to discover true portraits of that impassioned creature known as man.

The *teatro dei Fiorentini* is fresh and pretty; yet the proscenium arch is far too narrow, while the *décor* is as stale and as insipid as the music, for all that the latter is generally popular, and was greeted tonight with an awed and respectful silence. In fact, on two or three occasions, a prolonged and urgent *shushing* was heard to usher in the best-loved passages in the score.

And yet, when all is said and done, what lamentable stuff it was! All in the same, monotonous key—the echoes of an ice-cold disposition grimly resolved to utter ‘sentiment’. The outcome was *vapid* beyond belief: but then, all fools adore *opera semi-seria*; their minds can grasp *melodrama*, whereas true comedy eludes their understanding. There are infinitely greater depths of human truth to be discovered in the traditional *opera buffa*—recall, for instance, the sample we saw at Capua. The popularity of Guglielmi’s music (here, facts brook no denial) is phenomenal, and the applause comes deep from the heart; but no amount of applause can alter the plain, irrevocable truth of the matter, which is that such music is nothing but *ingenuity in vain pursuit of genius*; such, indeed, is the very theme-song of our century. Why, oh why does signor Guglielmi not make his home in Paris? There, by unanimous accord, he would be long and loud acclaimed a *great man*. Indeed, what is he else, but Grétry reborn into another age—a Grétry whose style is in part redeemed of its all-pervading *pettiness*. Mark also that his music still wears the semblance of a powdered wig (if the reader will forgive me so ill-judged and yet so picturesque a metaphor); while here and there, to give his tunes a touch of piquancy, this same *great man* will shamelessly ‘borrow’ a dozen bars or so from Rossini—which ‘borrowing’ falls into the same category as Natoire or de Troye plundering a head from Guido Reni.

12th February. The long-awaited day at last: the gala-opening of the new *San-Carlo**. Farewell, sweet reason! What place has reason among such multitudes, amid such splendid tiers of boxes? There were not a few fists flying, not a few rude elbowings to be endured or given. . . . Indeed, I was resolved to keep my temper, and in that I was successful; but my triumph cost me both tails off my coat. My seat in the pit cost me two-and-thirty *carlins* (14 fr.); my tenth share in a third-tier box, no less than five whole *sequins*.

And in those first instants, I did verily believe myself borne away into the Palace of some Emperor of the East. My eyes were dazzled, my soul was transported. The loftiest imagination can conceive no scene more flower-like in its freshness, nor more impressive in its grandeur—two qualities which are not commonly met and reconciled. This first evening, I have surrendered utterly to pleasure; I have not strength enough to criticise. I am exhausted. Tomorrow will be time enough to describe those odd, those singular sensations which came to affright the assembled audience.

13th February. Standing once more within the theatre, I discovered anew that sense of awe and ecstasy. Search to the farthest boundaries of Europe, you will find nothing to rival it—what am I saying? Nothing to give so much as the haziest glimmering of the meaning of it. This mighty edifice, rebuilt in the space of three hundred days, is nothing less than a *coup d'état*: it binds the people in fealty and homage to their sovereign far more effectively than any *Constitution*, such as that which was granted to Sicily, and which a host of folk would dearly like to see extended to Naples, a realm which surely ranks as high. From Prince to pot-boy, all Naples is drunk with delight. . . .

And indeed, so delirious was I in contemplation of that noble building, that I found the music and the ballets no less enchanting than the rest. The auditorium is a symphony in silver and gold, while the boxes are blue as the deep sky. The ornamentation of the inner wall—which is cut away in front of each box to form a balcony—is moulded in high-relief. Indeed, it is this above all which sets the stamp of such magnificence—these golden torches artfully grouped and interspersed with massive *fleurs-de-lis*. At intervals, this frieze of ornament, which is of unimaginable richness, is cut by bands of low-relief in silver. Of these I counted, unless I am mistaken, in all some six-and-thirty.

The boxes, which have no curtains, are unusually spacious. I could generally observe some five or six persons seated at each balcony.

There is a wondrous chandelier, all shimmering with light which is mirrored and refracted on every hand as it falls upon the gold and silver of the reliefs—an effect which would be lost utterly if the ornaments were two-dimensional. I can conceive of nothing more majestic, nor more magnificent, than the sumptuous Royal Box, which is set astride the central doorway, raised aloft on two great golden palm-trees, each of natural size; the hangings are fashioned out of leaves of metal, tinted in palest red; even the crown, that superannuated emblem, seems scarcely too absurd. In startling contrast to the sumptuous grandeur of the Royal Box, I could picture nothing daintier nor more elegant than the tiny *incognito* boxes of the second tier, set hard against the proscenium of the stage. The hangings of blue satin, the mirrors and the gilt reliefs are apportioned with exquisite artistry and taste, the like of which I have not met in Italy. The darting light, which seeks out every corner of the building, reveals each minute detail to the eye of the beholder.

The ceiling* of painted canvas is a faultless mirror of that taste in art prescribed by the French school; it is one of the hugest paintings in existence. The same comments apply word for word to the drop-curtain. Both these works of art are notable monuments to a sterile inspiration.

I was forgetting to describe the panic which took possession of the feminine half of the audience on the night of the 12th. Towards the fifth or sixth scene of the gala-cantata, it was gradually remarked that the vast well of the auditorium was imperceptibly beginning to fill with a cloud of dark smoke. Soon, this billow began to thicken. At nine o'clock or thereabouts, I chanced to glance in the direction of the Duchess of C***, whose box lay next to our own; I had just observed her remarkable pallor, when she leaned towards me and whispered

in accents of splendid terror: '*Ah! Santissima Madonna!* The theatre is on fire! They have tried once and failed; now they mean to try again. What will become of us?' In that instant, she was loveliness itself; her eyes, in particular, were of surpassing beauty. 'Signora', said I, 'if you can discover no worthier escort than an acquaintance of two days' standing, permit me to offer you my arm.' The great fire at the reception of Prince Schwarzenberg* flashed promptly into my mind; and even as I spoke with her, I recall that I was beginning to wrestle with a series of disquieting calculations; yet, in all honesty, more on her account than on my own. We were perched up in the third tier; the stairway was excessively narrow; there was destined to be a panic flight to safety. So absorbed was I in my search for some means to escape, that it was not until some two or three seconds had already elapsed that I grew suddenly aware of the distinctive smell of the 'smoke'. 'Why', said I to my fair neighbour, 'it is not smoke at all, but *fog* or condensation; the building, which is thoroughly damp, is drying out suddenly beneath the heat of such a multitude!' I realised then that everybody had arrived simultaneously at a similar conclusion, which, logical as it was, had none the less failed to save them from at least one unforgettable instant of panic; I realised further that, had it not been for the presence of the Court and the fear of adverse comment, those boxes would have been empty in a flash. Towards midnight, I made a round of visits: the women were perished with weariness, with dark rings round their eyes, their nerves on edge and never farther from the thought of pleasure, etc., etc.

14th February. The *San-Carlo* affords me a joy which seems well-nigh inexhaustible: the delights of great architecture are rare enough in all conscience! As for the delights of music, on the other hand, it would be unwise to seek them at the *San-Carlo*: whatever music there may be is inaudible. Of course, the Neapolitans themselves think quite differently;

they will swear their souls away that they can hear every note. My acquaintance from Milan has given me a footing in several boxes; tonight, on every side, I heard women complaining that they were *too visible*: not being able to believe my ears, I asked them to repeat this improbable piece of criticism. It seems that, thanks to the flood of illumination in the auditorium, the ladies find themselves perpetually 'on display'—an intolerable circumstance in any event, but here made four times as vexatious by the presence of a Court and royalty. Signora R*** was bitterly lamenting the curtained boxes of the *teatro alla Scala*. The central chandelier completely ruins the effect of any set on the stage; yet the *décor*, I suspect, is past praying for anyway, being almost as intolerable as the stuff one sees in Paris. All the theatres here fall under the responsibility of some great nobleman. The *décor* as a whole is spoilt by a common fault which shatters any dramatic illusion which it might otherwise produce; for the flats are constructed invariably some eight or ten inches *too short*, with the result that there is a constant procession of *feet* to be observed moving about below the pediments of the columns or among the roots of the trees. It is hard to conceive the absurdity of this perpetual distraction: the spectator's attention is held in hypnotic fascination by this shifting frieze of legs, and his fancy is constrained to guess at the purpose of each move.

Tonight, at the *San-Carlo*, I ran into an old acquaintance, Colonel Lange: he is the Town-Commandant of Naples under the Austrian administration; and during the course of the evening he introduced me to his remarkably handsome wife*. The day after tomorrow I am to dine with him, together with some eight or ten Austrian officers. Such patronage is worth decidedly more than the 'protection' of my so-called Ambassador.

The *Cantata**, which we endured at the gala-opening, is in the grossest vein of sixteenth-century flattery; the text has not a redeeming feature, no more than has the music. We in

France have learned that the most hypocritical flattery may be tricked out in the ingenuous simplicity of a popular catch. I should have thought that signor Lampredi might have had sense enough to copy this notion.¹ In this field, the purest genius is that of Metastasio. I know of no more brilliant handling of almost insuperable problems.

I have just been to the reading-rooms. The *Journal des Débats*, I discover, has recently been deemed *too liberal*, and banned!

20th February. Naples, like Paris, is a great capital city; this, perhaps, is the reason why I find so little to record. I pass my days contentedly enough; but by bedtime (praise the Lord!) I find that I have nothing new to write about; consequently, I can retire to rest without sitting up half the night and working. I am received 'at home' by the Princess Belmonte, likewise by that most charming of men, the *marchese* Berio, and I am treated with that same impeccable courtesy which has already been accorded to some five hundred or so foreign visitors in the past, and will doubtless be shown to a couple of hundred more during the coming year. There is nothing save the rarest of *nuances* to distinguish the tone which reigns in such company from that of polite society in Paris. Conversation is livelier here, perhaps, and assuredly *noisier*; now and then, the chatter reaches to such a pitch of stridency that it gives me the ear-ache. Naples, alone among Italian cities, has the true makings of a capital; the rest are nothing but glorified provincial towns, like Lyon.

¹ Signor Lampredi is responsible for the only readable Literary Review since the days of Baretti's *il Poligrafo* (Milan 1811). Other publications, under the rubric: *Literature*, offer nothing but a series of ponderous dissertations, not one of which would be admitted across the threshold of the *Académie des Inscriptions et Belles-Lettres*, or else a species of poetic lucubration worthy of M. Berthellemot. Just glance at the *Biblioteca Italiana*, of Milan, a journal whose editor, signor Acerbi, is a salaried minion of the Metternich government: nothing further need be said. [1817]

23rd February. It was singularly *naïve* of me, at my age, ever to have imagined that a public institution could divide its attention between two different objects simultaneously. If the theatre is magnificent, the music must necessarily be abject; if the music is enchanting, the theatre must be shoddy beyond redemption.

The credit for having rebuilt the *San-Carlo* must go entirely to a gentleman by the name of Barbaja. Signor Barbaja, a Milanese by birth and a man of uncommonly handsome appearance, began his career as a waiter in a coffee-house; soon, by holding the bank at faro, he became a millionaire; and out of the anticipated profits of his monopoly of the bank, he built the *San-Carlo*. The old King wanted to engage signora Catalani: the notion was sensible enough; Galli, Crivelli and Tacchinardi should likewise have been invited to join the company; but there—signor Barbaja had a *protégée*, and that *protégée* was a signorina Colbran. As for Nozzari, who was so brilliant as Paolino* when we used to watch him in Paris (but alas! that was fourteen years ago)—I have no idea whose *protégé* he was. As things stand, the most impressive member of the company is the younger Davide; but it is really painful to witness the desperate efforts this poor young man is forced to make in order to pitch his brilliant but delicate voice into the cavernous immensity of this great vault. He has picked up from Nozzari the trick of producing a certain type of trill made with the head-voice. What he needs most urgently is a *small* theatre to sing in, together with a good teacher; even so, he is the finest tenor in Italy: Tacchinardi is losing his voice, and Crivelli is as perfect as a mechanical instrument, and is fast becoming just as soulless.

I was much struck by the orchestra. Its playing is precise and controlled; each instrument, when its turn comes to make an entry, attacks the note with open confidence. The execution as a whole is no less firm than that of the *Orchestre Favart*, while its tone is much lighter than is commonly met with

among Viennese orchestras; in consequence, its *piano* passages are particularly impressive.

The *San-Carlo* is as far ahead of *la Scala* in the brilliance of its orchestral performance as the Neapolitan theatre is inferior to the Milanese in the poverty of its *décor* and the shoddiness of its costumes. Tonight, we had a *bellissimo teatro*—in other words, every seat in the house was taken. It was the Princess Belmonte who observed that, amid such a rich profusion of brilliant surfaces, all the women seemed to be dressed in *dirty grey*, while their very cheeks seemed to bear the complexion of lead. Ideally, the auditorium of a theatre should be decorated in various shades of grey rather than in bright colours.

Italian audiences cherish a most singular passion for *premières* (*prime sere*). Good, honest folk, who order their lives in strictest economy from one year's end to the next, will nonchalantly squander forty guineas on a box for the first night of a new opera. Tonight, for instance, I observed, in the box of signora Formigini*, a group of *dilettanti* who had travelled all the way from Venice for the occasion, and who are due to start off home again tomorrow. The people of Italy are close-fisted as misers over the small things of life, yet reckless to the point of prodigality over the things that really matter; in France, where vanity occurs more commonly than passion, we abide by an opposite principle.

King Ferdinand basks in a kind of effulgent glory reflected from the magnificence of the *San-Carlo*; he can be seen in his Royal Box *sharing* the ecstatic delight of the audience; and indeed, this word *sharing* draws the veil of oblivion over a very multitude of sins. (Anecdote concerning the cradle of the newly-born *Infanta*, and the petition therein deposited, humbly begging for the life of the beautiful *contessa* San-Felice, who was hanged in 1799; I heard this tale from the lips of a certain Neapolitan, who was much incensed at the sudden surge of monarchistic fervour inspired in myself by the noble architecture of the *San-Carlo*. 'This theatre', he concluded, 'is

here for all to behold; but what you do *not* see is the life of the smaller towns.' He had every right to offer me this sharp reproof. From what he was saying, I deduce that the Neapolitan peasant is little better than a savage, yet happy as were the natives of Tahiti before the advent of the *Methodist missionaries*.)

28th February. In the company of my sixteen-year-old *duchessa*, I visited the collection of paintings owned by *il cavaliere Ghigi*. My fair companion, I learned, was involved in a situation romantic enough in all conscience to form the plot of a novel, yet too delicate, perhaps, to be used as such within the framework of our present conventions. Prince Corvi, being in love with *la contessina* Carolina, the mother of my young *duchessa*, yet tasting all the bitterness of jealousy, for that he could find no means to loosen the tender bonds of her affection for the *cavaliere* P***, decided to reveal the secret of this *liaison* to the lady's husband, an amiable-tempered fellow, who refused to believe a word of this ill-timed denunciation. Baffled at the first attempt, the Prince resolved to go a step further, and repeated his denunciation to the *contessina's* daughters, two charming and innocent creatures of fifteen or sixteen summers, who were most tenderly attached to their mother. These two unhappy children were so distressed by the discovery, that they privately resolved together to take the veil; they grew embarrassed in their mother's presence, and durst no longer speak a word to her. At long last, the elder of the two, falling upon her knees at her mother's feet, burst into tears and unburdened herself of all the tale of Prince Corvi's denunciation, together with the secret of their common resolution to enter a convent, lest they should suffer the contamination of a *woman taken in adultery*. Imagine the atrocious dilemma of the *contessina*—a mother torn between her adoration for her lover and her implacable sense of honour. By good fortune, she retained sufficient presence of mind to deny the

whole story. This little narrative—which takes some twenty minutes in the telling—is perhaps one of the most beautiful and most moving episodes I have encountered in a year.

All Italy is no bigger than a cabbage-patch, and the wealthier families of one city are as well-acquainted with those of another as though they were next-door neighbours; were it not for this fact, there are two or three dozen episodes in similar vein which I could dearly wish to set down here, in place of all these abstract moral observations: for, in assessing the moral climate of a nation, any statement which is *vague* is *ipso facto* wrong. The reader whose boldest excursion has taken him no further than from Paris to Saint-Cloud, and who therefore is familiar with no manners other than those of his native land, will necessarily ascribe to such words as *decency*, *virtue*, *duplicity* and so on a significance materially different from that which *you*, my Italian friend, may have intended to convey by such expressions.

On one occasion, for instance, in Bologna, among the guests assembled at signora N***, I met a young woman, *la Ghita*, whose career might furnish the matter for the most fascinating, and indeed the most noble of romances, on condition that every detail were left intact and undisturbed. In my own *Journal*, this narrative fills up the space of some eleven pages: never was there a more vivid portrait of the manners of modern Europe and of that subtle shade of sensibility peculiar to Italy, nor a story which rises so many thousand leagues above the dutiful inventions of our novelists, nor yet a tale so full of incident, so alive with unexpected twists and turns, yet ever true to nature. It is the recurrent weakness of *comedy of character*, that the audience may easily foresee each separate eventuality which lies in wait to ensnare the hero; here likewise, the *hero* whom *la Ghita* so desperately adored (and still adores today, for all I know) is commonplace enough; the *jealous husband* is no less of a stock character; the *mother*, a caricature of inhuman ferocity; only the *leading lady* achieves a truly heroic stature*. But, once

granting this, one might well scour the cities of London and of Paris, and gather up every woman of feeling in the two capitals, and pound them all together in a mortar, without ever extracting so rich a residue of sensibility as would endow a character of such unfathomable depth and energy. Yet all this wealth lies buried deep beneath a mask of plain simplicity, if not of coldness. I shall never cease to wonder at the inexhaustible store of energy which is seen to reside in the character of certain Italian women. A casual hint of coldness from their lover will rankle still within their hearts some six months after, and be treasured for sure retaliation or revenge; never will the memory of it, through weakness, be allowed to fade, or else be overlaid with other cares, as would occur in France. In Germany, a woman will forgive all, and, in the very devotion of her doting soul, forget. In England, among women of intelligence, some echo of this boundless sensibility may be found; but all too often it is vitiated by prudishness.

This *sensibility*, so characteristic of Italy, is plain absurdity in the estimation of the North. I have been pondering the problem for the last fifteen minutes, yet even now I have no notion, no conception even, how to explain, what terms to use to express this quality, to make it fit for northern understandings. The highest rational achievement of the finest intellects consists in grasping that certain matters lie beyond their power to grasp. In other words, the problem is, of its very nature, insoluble—like a tiger who would persuade a stag of the succulent joys of a carnivorous diet!

I am privately aware that these very words I have been writing are absurd; such mysteries belong to an arcane, esoteric doctrine, whose secrets should never be allowed to fall on vulgar ears.

2nd March. Benefit-performance for Louis Duport*, the dancer. His last appearance on the stage. Such an occasion, in Naples, is truly momentous.

I was forgetting to mention the *décor* of his ballet, *Cinderella*. These sets were designed by an artist who is intimately acquainted with those laws which govern the *terrible* in art. The *Fairy's Palace*, with its funereal lamps, and that gigantic figure, sixty feet in height, whose stature dwarfs the very proscenium arch, while his finger points blindly towards the fatal star, stamps an enduring picture on the mind. But no mere words can make the thrill of such impressions comprehensible in Paris. The one defect of this noble set lay in its feeble colouring, together with a certain weakness in *chiaroscuro* (a lack of energy in the contrasting masses of light and shade).

This *Fairy's Palace* scene, together with another set from the same ballet which depicts a ballroom, faithfully modelled on *Stonehenge* and set in the depths of a forest, would be outstanding even in Milan. All in all, the Lombard designers have a far surer appreciation of the magic spell of *colour*; on the other hand, their actual designs are sometimes weak and ineffective—a fault which springs from a certain banality in the original conception. In Naples, trees are painted green, whereas, at *la Scala*, they appear *grey-blue*. Tonight's *la Cenerentola*, together with *Astolfo e Giocondo* (choreography by Vestris), are danced almost step for step as they might be in Paris; only the presence among the cast of Marianna Conti and Antonia Pallerini (an inspired mime, comparable with Giuditta Pasta) allows the programme to shed something of the frigidity of the French tradition; the cold technical perfection and the courtly graces of this latter school, however, are well represented by madame Duport, by Salvatore Taglioni and his niece Maria. As far as Duport himself is concerned, my admiration is a long-standing affair, dating back over many years; nor did I forsake my constancy tonight. I find his movements as fascinating as those of a kitten; I could sit for hours on end and watch him dance.

At tonight's performance, the audience could scarcely contain the wild tempests of its applause: indeed, the King in

person gave the lead. From the box where I sat, I could hear the thunder of His Majesty's voice, and the enthusiasm grew rapidly to the proportions of a *furor*, which lasted fully three-quarters of an hour. Duport has lost none of the lightness which so delighted us in Paris in his interpretation of *Figaro*. Never is there the least suggestion of effort; step by step, the rhythm of his dancing grows fiercer, until, by the end, he is possessed by the very ecstasy and intoxication of that passion which animates his movements; indeed, the art of ballet itself can attain to no higher degree of expression; or at least, to be precise, *I* have never witnessed anything even comparable. By contrast, Vestris and Taglioni—in this, neither better nor worse than all mediocre dancers—can neither conceal the effort required, nor yet master the secret of *progression* in their dancing. In consequence, even the flavour of *sensuality* is missing from their interpretation; and sensuality, after all, is the primary aim of art. Here, at the *San-Carlo*, the women seem to be better dancers than the men; next to the voluptuous delights of sensuality, *admiration* is the chief emotion aroused by ballet—which two sensations, taken together, all but exhaust the compass of this, the narrowest of the arts. The eye, held in strange enchantment by the brilliance of the *décor* and the originality of the grouping, should, by coaxing the mind into a state of keen and tender receptivity, predispose it thus to appreciate the passions which the dance will illustrate.

I have been admirably placed to appreciate the difference between the two contrasting styles of ballet. Italian audiences are only too willing to admit the superiority of the French school, yet, all unsuspecting, are infinitely more susceptible to the peculiar genius of their own. Duport must indeed be satisfied, for there was no stinting in tonight's applause; yet the true, the heart-felt, the unbounded transports were reserved for Marianna Conti. My neighbour this evening was a Frenchman, a man of taste and breeding, who, at one point, being overwhelmed by the flood of emotions which possessed him,

so far forgot himself as to address me a remark. '*Gross indecency!*' he kept repeating, over and over again. How right he was, indeed—and how much more so the audience in its ecstasy! For, after all, *indecency* is, by and large, a matter of convention; whereas ballet, as an art, relies almost wholly upon a positive degree of sensuality which is the sheer delight of Italy and the shocked despair of France. The Italian, caught up in that great provocative surge of rhythm and movement, will never once be visited by the slightest notion of indecency; in the pure perfection of art lies all his joy, much as a French audience may be held enthralled by the exquisite poetry of *Cinna*, yet never be shocked by the patent absurdity of the *unity of place*. In an art which is made up all of fleeting impressions, faults unperceived have no reality. A thing which is *charming* in Paris may be *indecent* in Geneva—such judgments are parochial affairs, depending wholly upon the degree of prudishness dictated by the local incumbent. Jesuitry is infinitely more propitious to art and human happiness than *Methodism*.

Whither should we turn to seek the *immutable ideal* of ballet? As yet, no such universal criterion of beauty has been discovered. Ballet, as an art, is too directly dependent upon climatic influences and upon the physical constitution of the human body. The *immutable ideal* would need to be fashioned anew every three hundred miles.

The French school has attained no higher than the height of *technical* perfection.

In the present age, what is needed is a genius to *use* these techniques, so painstakingly acquired. Ballet, in our time, is at the same stage as painting was when Masaccio appeared upon the scene. There *is* a genius alive today, and dwelling here in Naples; yet his art is despised and ill-considered—Viganò, the creator of *gli Zingari** (the *Gypsies*). The good folk of Naples were convinced that he was having a joke at their expense; for this particular ballet chanced to bring to light a most curious fact, whose truth had hitherto been unsuspected—

namely, that the general moral climate of the Kingdom of Naples is identical, custom for custom, with that of the Romany. (Cf. Cervantes' *Novelas*.) And thus it comes about that Viganò can point a moral for the legislators of the realm—so closely indeed is each art bound up part and parcel with the rest! Yet at the same time it is a major triumph, in the mastery of so recalcitrant an art, to have compelled it to express, portray—indeed, to portray so *well*—the manners of a society rather than the passions of a race (*i.e.*, habitual characteristics of behaviour in the pursuit of happiness, rather than violent humours and general moods). There was one episode in particular, where the dancers moved to an accompaniment of timpani, which shocked the poor Neapolitans to the very depths of their being; they were convinced that the whole thing was a deliberate hoax; and indeed yesterday, among the guests of Princess Belmonte, I met a young captain who would fret and storm himself into a very frenzy at the mere mention of Viganò. Naples today is in a decidedly curious frame of mind, nor may it hope to return to normal without a couple of resounding military victories in the style of Austerlitz or Marengo; until such time, the Neapolitans are fated to remain distinctly *touchy*. 'Yet', I might say to them without any sense of undue generosity, 'what mortal man had greater valour than signor di Rocca-Romana? Is it the fault of gentlemen of birth and breeding, if the tonsured hoards have eaten the heart out of the common people, who were rich in courage when they went by the name of Samnites, and yet are grown so crawling and contemptible since they took to worshipping San Gennaro?' The history of this ballet, and the subsequent tale of its repercussions, shed a sudden shower of light within my mind, and indeed set me finally on the proper path in my resolve to study this corner of the world. It was Noverre (so I am told) who discovered the *sensual* element in dancing; Viganò has widened its horizon of *expression* at every point. Yet this same unerring instinct for his art impelled him further,

and led him to disclose the ultimate secret of the ballet, which is that ballet is *par excellence* the art of the *romantic*. The loftiest heights to which the spoken drama may attain have long since been scaled by Shakespeare; but *il Noce di Benevento* is not merely a feast of delight for the entranced imagination, but explores a realm of fancy unknown to *Imogen* in her *Cave*, or to the *melancholy Jacques* in the *Forest of Arden*. So vivid is the joy, so captivating the originality of it, that the soul, transported, knows no release from ecstasy from curtain-rise to curtain-fall—full five-and-seventy minutes; and although I never dare entrust to paper the fever-heat of such experience, for fear of earning ridicule beyond redemption, yet the memory of it lives on despite the years. No fleeting sketch in words can adequately convey the impressions of such an instant; only a boundless flood of talking, which should end by kindling the very depths of the listener's fancy. At home in France, in the Château de B***, I recall once how madame R*** held us all enraptured in the drawing-room until past three in the morning with her impressions of *il Noce di Benevento**. The secret of watching ballet is first to fill the imagination with pictures remembered from the old Spanish dramatists and from the *Novelas ejemplares*, so that fancy herself may embroider every predicament without external stimulus; furthermore, the mind should be already weary of words as a means for developing situations. Thus each individual fancy, fired to fever-heat by the music, may take wings and furnish forth speech of its own invention to set upon the lips of these ever-silent actors. Hence we may discover that ballet—ballet as Viganò has conceived it—may move with a speed which even Shakespeare could not emulate. Yet alas! it is to be feared that this inimitable art will soon vanish for ever; the peak of its achievement was reached in Milan, in the old, prosperous days of the Kingdom of Italy. Ballet demands vast financial resources, whereas *la Scala* is now so impoverished that I doubt whether it can survive above two or three years more: the present

Tyrant, unlike Lorenzo de' Medici, is in no way concerned to hide the chains of his oppression and the spiritual degradation of his subjects behind a glittering mask of art. Now that a squeamish piety has suppressed the gaming-rooms, from the profits of which the theatre proper used to be subsidised, the very memory of this art may well be fated to vanish from the mind of man; nothing will remain of it, save the name alone, like those of Roscius and Pylades. Paris never beheld its glory, and so it has remained but dimly known in all the rest of Europe.

Whenever the Milanese start talking to foreigners about *Coriolano* or *Prometeo*, about *il Noce di Benevento* or *Samandria liberata*, the listener*, unless he be endowed with the rarest gifts of a picturesque imagination, invariably finds his fancy chilled to freezing-point by the wild ecstasies of his companion. And since we in France are but most shabbily endowed with picturesque imaginations,¹ this medium of art would fall resoundingly flat. Our worthy Academicians—like La Harpe—are unable to grasp even so simple a phenomenon as Metastasio. I personally have seen no more than three or four ballets by Viganò. His imagination has about it a certain *Shakespearian* quality—yet the very name of Shakespeare, I suspect, would mean nothing to him*. Painting and music alike have a share in his genius. Frequently, when he cannot lay hands on a melody ready-fashioned to express his meaning, he will compose his own. I would be the last to deny that his *Prometeo* is entirely free from absurdities; yet, ten years after, the memory of it lives on as fresh as ever, and my mind is still astonished at its power. A further and most original characteristic of Viganò's genius is his *patience*. He will stand on the stage at *la Scala*, surrounded by eighty dancers, with a band of ten musicians in the orchestra-pit at his feet, there to spend a whole morning composing and implacably rehearsing, over

¹ This quality, I suspect, may not uncommonly be found in Scotland. [1817]

and over again, ten bars of choreography which seem to him to fall short of final perfection. There is no stranger sight in all the world—yet I had vowed never to let myself speak of Viganò.

Memory is the sweet seductress who has tempted me astray. It is striking two o'clock in the morning: Vesuvius is erupting fire; I can see the lava streaming down the mountain-side, whose red mass stands out in sharp-cut contours against the indescribable dark beauty of the horizon. Three-quarters of an hour have I sat here at my window, perched high on the seventh floor, contemplating this sight, at once so new and so impressive.

5th March. 'In due course of time', remarked Monsignor R*** this evening, 'the *immutable ideal* of ballet will be established, and found to reside at some point between the far extremes of Duport and Marianna Conti. But first of all, some rich and pleasure-loving Prince must provide a *Court*—and that, alas! is a sight we ne'er shall see again. Each royal ruler is first and foremost concerned to set aside a sum of millions in the bank, that he may continue, should need arise and his Dynasty be overthrown, to live at least the life of a wealthy private citizen. The sovereigns of the present age, moreover, being resolved and adamant to oppose the wishes of their subjects, are fashioning for themselves one and all a life-long prospect of disquiet. This grave miscalculation may well result in the decay of art throughout the nineteenth century. In the twentieth century, the nations will know no better subject to discuss than politics; and folk will read the *Morning Chronicle* instead of clapping Marianna Conti.'

The chilly perfection which characterises the style of Mademoiselle Fanny Bias may in no wise be accommodated to this aesthetic ideal of ballet—at least, nowhere outside France. Were it given to me to make a choice between these

two contrasting elements of *ideal beauty*, I confess freely that I should prefer the living, vivid *sensuality* of la Conti.¹ Some eight or ten years since, Mademoiselle Milière, equipped with all her faultless Parisian technique, appeared in Milan, danced—and was whistled off the stage forthwith. Whereupon she learned to breathe life into her rôles; and so, today, she is the very idol of *la Scala*—and doubtless would be hounded off the stage in Paris.

Yesterday, I climbed to the crater of Vesuvius; never in my life have I known such exhaustion. The devilish part of the ascent lay up the cone of ash which marks the summit. Yet, who knows? In a month's time, the whole landscape may have changed beyond recognition. *Hermits* (so-called) are as likely as not to be *robbers*, converted or otherwise: this resounding platitude I discovered in a book, duly signed by Bigot de Préameneu. I should need ten pages and the talents of Mrs Radcliffe, were I to describe the view which awaits the weary traveller's gaze as he sits down to consume his omelette, made to order for him by the Hermit of Vesuvius. Nor will I utter a word touching Pompeï, which is the most astounding, the most fascinating, the most entertaining spectacle I have ever encountered; no other sight on earth can furnish such *understanding* of antiquity. What endless speculations concerning the nature of art arise in the mind, as one contemplates the Fresco of the Minotaur, and indeed a score of others! Three times a week at least I pay a visit to Pompeï.

¹ The ballets of Gardel bear absolutely no relation to those of Viganò: the former is a dwarfish *Campistron* beside the latter's *Shakespeare*. Viganò, had he treated the same subject, would have made the onlookers tremble for his *Psyche*; Gardel, in the scene where he allows her to be tormented by the satanic host, falls into the same error as Shakespeare, when he allows a dethroned King to have his eyes gouged out on the stage, in full view of the audience. The spectator's imagination, being insufficiently stirred to feel this strong intensity of horror, is merely amused by the ugliness of the devil-brood, and laughs out loud at their green talons.
[1817]

14th March. I have just been to see *Astolfo e Giocondo*, by Vestris III, grandson of him they called *le diou de la danse*. Considered as ballet, this was miserable stuff. Duport's version of the same tale is scarcely better: garlands *ad nauseam*, scarves and favours for damsels to bestow upon their knights and tender shepherdesses upon their swains in soft exchange of tokens; followed by a *pas-de-deux* (with scarves or favours aforementioned) in celebration of the solemn ritual! What countless leagues from this to that scene in *la Samandria liberata*, where the young bridegroom, his very soul consumed with jealousy, sets foot once more within his Palace, and yet, in spite of all, is swept up in that wondrous *pas-de-trois* with his bride and the Negress who is his slave and mistress of the music in his own seraglio. No one who watched it but was bewitched heart and soul—yet none could tell why. This was one of the greatest chapters in the *Anatomy of Love*: all past offences shuffled off into oblivion by the presence of the beloved object. Our taste in France might be compared with that of some lovely woman who refuses to allow the artist to use any *shadow* in the portrait of her he is making; it is like a painting by Boucher beside Gros' masterpiece, the *Hospital at Jaffa*. At long last, I have no doubt, this mincing, periwigged nonsense will vanish from the face of the earth; but *we* shall have vanished likewise some years before. We have not enjoyed enough security for the great *Revolution* to make its influence felt in the field of art. Art and letters still linger on amid the sickly talents of the age of Louis XV: witness MM. de Fontanes, Villemain, etc.

In normal circumstances, nothing can deepen the contempt I feel for French music; however, my friends in France, by the letters they had written, had almost caused me to waver in my disdain. It needed but a little more persuasion, and I might have conceded them a certain gift for lively tunes, a talent for meaningless but pretty melody. But tonight's experience of the ballet-music to *Giocondo* puts a final end to

all argument, as far as I am concerned. Never have I been made more vividly aware of the poverty, the barrenness, the gross, pretentious *impotence* of our music than through this score, into which have been poured pell-mell all those tunes by common consent avowed the prettiest, all those melodies which (once upon a time) could touch my heart. The awareness of true *Beauty* is stronger even than the haunting memories of youth. Such remarks as these are bound to seem absurd, outrageous, nay more, grotesque, *abominable*, to those whose minds are unacquainted with *Beauty* in her purest forms. But there! in any case, all *good and patriotic citizens* have assuredly cast this book into the fire a long while since, with horrified despair: 'The Author is not *French*!'

The vast size of both stage and auditorium at the *San-Carlo* is admirable for ballet. A squadron of eight-and-forty horse can manoeuvre with room and to spare in Duport's *Cinderella**, in which performance the cavalry aforementioned, and the various modes of combat in which they indulge, contribute a whole act to the drama—excessively boring, thoroughly unconvincing and exceptionally well-conceived to appeal to the vulgar taste of the multitude. The cavalry performs a charge at full gallop right to the very brink of the footlights. The riders are Germans—no Italian horseman could ever hope to keep in the stirrups under such circumstances. The ballet-school attached to the *San-Carlo* holds out the fairest promise for the future: signorina Mersi may, or may not, make a name for herself sooner or later, but in any case she is remarkably pretty. As a dancer, she has genuine originality of style.

Today—March 14th—I was seriously incommoded by the heat as I stood contemplating the *Farnese Bull*, set square in the middle of the delightful *riviera di Chiaja*, scarce twenty paces from the sea. In the country-side, all the apple-trees are flowering, and the almonds are covered with blossom; whereas in Paris, the winter has still another couple of months to go. Yet in Paris, a man may spend each evening in a different *salon*, nor

ever fail to pick up two or three original ideas. So here indeed is a problem with no ready solution: *which of the two is preferable?*

15th March. A delightful ball given at the Royal Palace. Fancy-dress was the order of the evening, with masks in character; but soon enough the masks were set aside. I enjoyed myself hugely from eight at night until four in the morning. All *London* was present; and, in my opinion, it was the peerless beauties of Albion who carried off the prize. Yet there were not a few fair Neapolitans among the throng—among others, that unhappy little creature, *la contessa* N***, who, once a month, sets out for Terracina* to visit her lover. The *Master of the Household* is in no way deserving of all those resounding denunciations and slanderous diatribes in the manner of Tacitus which are hurled at him from every corner of Europe; he is just another *Squire Western*, straight out of *Tom Jones*—a sovereign who is far better versed in hunting boars than in hanging prisoners (1799–1822). . . . But hush! be silent, my tongue! For did I not promise that, wherever I might visit, unless I first had duly *paid* for my admission, I should observe discretion? Otherwise, the traveller's vocation lies dangerously near to that of *spy*.

16th March. Despite my profound contempt for modern architecture, I suffered myself this morning to be taken to visit signor Bianchi, of Lugano, sometime recipient of a pension from the Privy Purse of Napoleon. His designs are comparatively free from that plague of arabesques, angles and offsets which are the very stuff of contemporary pettiness (*cf.* the Courtyard of the *Louvre*), and whose malign influence can be detected even in Michelangelo. The present age is too dwarfish to grasp the truth that the Ancients never employed *decoration for its own sake*; and that, in classical architecture, beauty was invariably a by-product of *utility*. How should this current

generation of artists be expected to study the mirror of their own souls? Honourable men they may be, nor would I seek to deny it, and gifted with intelligence to boot; yet Mozart possessed a soul, and they do not. Never have they been swept headlong into the wild seas of extravagance by the strong surge of dreams and passions; in recognition of which sobriety they now sport the insignia of the *cordons noirs* . . . which confers nobility!

Signor Bianchi has recently been commissioned to design the church of *San Francesco di Paola*, in Naples, facing the Royal Palace. The actual labour of building is to be entrusted by His Majesty to signor Barbaja, and doubtless we shall see the edifice completed in eight or ten years' time*. It would be hard to conceive a site less suitable for a church—indeed, rather than build, it were preferable to knock down two or three dozen houses hereabouts. The ideal place for a church would be the *largo di Castello*; but, throughout the length and breadth of Europe, the arid winds of vanity have withered every heart, and men have grown blind to the *eternal principles* of beauty. Bianchi's design is based on curvilinear forms, which is evidence at least that he has a true eye for classical architecture; yet he has failed to grasp the significant fact that the Ancients, when they built a temple, had in mind a purpose diametrically opposed to ours when *we* build a church: for the Greeks, religion was a festival and not a threat. The Attic temple, beneath those unblemished skies, was nothing but a theatre of sacrifice. There was no kneeling, no prostration, no beating of breasts; instead, there was the sacred ritual of dancing. It is indeed hard to conceive that mankind should have.....

.....
 But there! *novelty* is a primary desire and need of the human imagination*.

In the course of my visit to signor Bianchi, I met the two most remarkable individuals in the whole kingdom: General

Filangieri and signor Cuoco, the Councillor of State.

17th March. I need waste but few words on such music as I have heard at the *San-Carlo*. I arrived in Naples beside myself with expectation; yet the greatest sum of pleasure I have known—and that not excessive—was the opera I listened to in Capua.

My first experience at the *San-Carlo* was Rossini's *Otello*. I can conceive of nothing more *chilling*.¹ The wretched librettist must have needed something very close to genius to reduce the most powerful tragedy that ever was on any stage to such a tasteless mess of insipidity. On the other hand, Rossini has aided and abetted him in every way he knew. The overture, admittedly, is of an astonishing originality, entrancing, easy to grasp, and full of irresistible charms for the unmusical, yet never tending to banality. Yet, when the subject of the tragedy is Othello, the music may have all these qualities, and still be hopelessly, shamelessly inadequate*. Neither in the whole life's-work of Mozart, nor yet in Haydn's *Seven Last Words of Christ*, is there any music too profound for such a subject. Indeed, the most satanic discords, together with all the wealth and all the dissonance of enharmonic writing, would scarce suffice to portray the villainous Iago (*cf.* Pergolesi, *Orfeo*, first recitative). Rossini, so I suspect, is himself insufficiently master of his own idiom to describe such things. Furthermore, he is too good-humoured, too merry, too fond of his food.

One of the absurdest sights, yet one rarely met with outside Italy, is that of the father or of the husband of a famous *prima*

¹ To punish myself for having entertained such unworthy thoughts in 1817, I am resolved to leave this epithet exactly as it stands. At the time, I was carried away, albeit unconsciously, by the tempest of my wrath against the *marchese* Berio, the author of that unspeakable *libretto* which turns Othello into a *Blue-Beard*! In the portrayal of the gentler emotions, Rossini (who has by now written himself out) never rose to within a thousand leagues of Mozart or Cimarosa; in compensation, however, he conceived a style so swift and glittering as these great masters never dreamed of. [1826]

donna: the term *dom Procolo** is commonly applied to designate such characters. On one occasion, Count Somaglia having chanced to offer his arm to the notorious Isabella Colbran, in order to show her round the premises of *la Scala*, her father, graver than a judge, proceeded to remark:

'You may deem yourself fortunate indeed, *signor conte*; are you aware that many a *Crowned Head* in Europe has thought it no dishonour to offer a royal arm to my daughter?'

'Sir!' retorted the Count, 'You forget that I am a married man!'

(The rejoinder has rather more spice in Italian.)

After *Otello*, I was obliged to sit through an opera called *Gabriele di Vergi*, by a young composer belonging to the Caraffa family. Stylistically, it was nothing but a slavish imitation of Rossini. However, the tenor Davide was nothing less than divine in the part of Coucy.¹

I have also seen another performance of Paër's *Sargino*: Davide, inspired by signorina Chabran from the *teatro dei Fiorentini*, gave a most ingenious interpretation. And yet I found this famous opera not a whit less tedious here in Naples than in Dresden. Paër and M. de Chateaubriand are birds of a feather: however hard I try to appreciate the genius of either, my heart refuses to respond; the whole affair seems absurd. M. de Chateaubriand exasperates me: his is a brilliant mind which takes *me* for an oaf. Signor Paër, on the other hand, just bores me to tears; I find his vast and steady popularity astounding.

18th March. This evening, the *San-Carlo* company gave a performance of *Otello* at the *teatro del Fondo*. I picked out quite

¹ Listening to the same opera today, I discover quite a number of deeply-moving passages. It is sufficient to hear one or two melodies by Caraffa or Perruchini interpreted by signorina Nina Viganò to realise that these two composers actually created the tradition of the *Italian song*—for instance, *il Travaso dell' Anima*. [1826]

a number of attractive themes, hitherto unsuspected: among others, the duet for two female voices in Act I.

These great, echoing caverns like the *San-Carlo* and *la Scala* are not the flowers of civilisation, but rather a brand of freakish and distorted excrescence. Each *nuance* must be magnified to monstrous size; but then, a *nuance* magnified is a *nuance* no more. Ideally, all aspiring singers should be reared in a *milieu* of unblemished chastity—yet nowadays, the very thought of such a thing is inconceivable. Cathedrals and choir-schools alone could have provided a suitable atmosphere. It is the common lament that Crivelli and Davide have no successors, Yet, since the great tradition of the old *castrati* declined and vanished, the deep secrets of music have vanished with them from the operatic stage. From sheer despair at their unnatural condition, these poor devils laboured to acquire the profoundest knowledge of their art. Invariably it was the *castrato* who, in *ensemble* passages, would bear the whole company upon his shoulders; he it was who alone could bring out latent genius in the *prima donna*, at once his pupil and his 'mistress'. Our present age owes surely two or three outstanding *prime donne* to Velluti.

Nowadays, as soon as the *tempo* offers the slightest difficulty, the singers give up in despair, and the poor listener might well be forgiven for imagining himself the victim of a crowd of *amateurs*. This curious phenomenon was well accounted for last night by Count Gallenberg, who explained it to the assembled guests of the *marchese* Berio. Italy and Germany are poles apart in this, for German music is harsh, bizarre and arid as the steppe, and would drive the wretched listener to despair and self-destruction, were not its creators the finest masters of the art of *tempo* that the world has ever known.

It is the established custom in Italy that the two hours' performance of an opera should be interrupted by an hour of ballet; and indeed, this tradition is based upon the feebleness of the human organism; it is, in point of fact, ridiculous to

overwhelm an audience with two acts of operatic music in quick succession. Observe likewise that ballet, as conceived by Viganò, is both impossible and absurd in a small theatre. Now, there is an acoustical conundrum which I should like to set our present crop of learned geometers to rack their brains about, and which these illustrious gentlemen will doubtless treat with contempt unbounded, for the simple reason that it is too difficult for them. Here is the problem: is it not possible to devise a theatre with two separate stages of different dimensions? Or alternatively, to design one dual-purpose, adaptable stage, which, after a ballet, can be cut lengthwise by a partition resonant enough to project a singer's voice far out into the auditorium? Would it be possible, for instance, to lower a metallic curtain? Or else, perhaps, to construct a wall of hollow wooden blocks, faced with a drum-head on the audience's side? In Parma, at the *teatro Farnese*, the sound of a piece of paper being torn at the back of the stage will re-echo all over the building. Here you have a genuine acoustic phenomenon in conditions which should be meticulously reproduced; but of course, it is much less trouble simply to deny it. And another thing: Italian architects are well aware that nothing is better calculated to still the dreams and halt the wanderings of a vagabond imagination, than an atmosphere deficient in oxygen.

19th March. The *San-Carlo*, indisputably, has the status of a patriotic symbol for the good people of Naples: national pride, crushed by the campaign which ended in the death of Joachim Murat, has sought refuge within its portals. But here is the truth, plain and unvarnished: the *San-Carlo*, considered as an *instrument for making music*, bears absolutely no comparison with *la Scala*. Gradually, as the masonry dries out, its acoustics may grow less muffled; on the other hand, all the bright glitter of gilt-work which was applied too early to the still-damp surfaces of the rough-cast plaster ornamentation will soon grow hopelessly tarnished. The *décor* is the last word in

banality, and moreover, offers no chance of improvement, since the effect is killed stone-dead by the central chandelier. This same chandelier has another disastrous result: it throws the actors' faces into shadow.

20th March. This evening, as I went to take my seat in the *San-Carlo*, a *gend'arme* came running after me and ordered me to remove my hat. The auditorium is a good four times the size of the *Grand Opéra* in Paris; yet I (*horribile dictu!*) had failed to notice the presence of God-knows-what insignificant princeling!

Paris is deservedly the capital of the universe, precisely because no man there knows his neighbour, while the Court is nothing but a sight to entertain the curious.

In Naples, the *San-Carlo* opens its doors but three times a week; consequently, as a *rendez-vous* for business transactions of every description, it offers none of the unfailing amenities of *la Scala*. If you explore the galleries, rows of *titles*, redolent of pomp and circumstance, and all writ large upon the doors of the private boxes, serve to remind you that you, poor worm, are but a zero, an atom, fit only to be blotted out for ever by an *Excellency*. Did you chance to cross the threshold in a *hat*? Then 'ware! for one of the heroic guard of Tolentino will soon be snapping at your heels. Does *la Conti* so enchant your eye and heart that you can scarce forbear to clap? Yet hold! for the presence of *His Majesty* turns all applause to guilt and sacrilege. Did you think to leave your seat among the benches of the pit? Tread warily, then, lest, as you pass among the crowd, you brush against some high-born *Nobleman*, his person draped in emblems, stars and orders, and by mischance, catch his *Chamberlain's Key* in your humble watch-chain loop (as it befell myself last night!)—for straightway, hark! the growl of '*disrespect*'! Wearied by such a surfeit of ceremony, would you resolve to leave the theatre and send for your hired carriage to take you home? Then be prepared to kick your heels and

wait, while some *Princess's* coach-and-six obstructs the door for an hour, no less . . . wait, and catch your death of cold meanwhile!

God be praised for great cities which have no Court! Not because of Their glorious Majesties, who, by and large, are egotistical, good-natured brutes, and who, by happy dispensation, have no leisure to turn their attentions towards the affairs of private individuals; but rather on account of that host of Ministers and Vice-Ministers of State, each one of whom is pleased to constitute himself a source of police-interference and molestation. This sort of nuisance, unknown in Paris, is the constant bane of daily life in almost every capital city in the continent of Europe. Yet what would you? Given eight or ten Ministers-of-State, whose official duties between the lot would scarcely occupy a single *préfet*, yet each and every one of whom is dying to be administering *something*, how else are they to pass the time away?

No sooner had I set foot in Naples than I learnt that the *Comptroller of the Opera* was a *Duke*; as a matter of course, therefore, I steeled myself well beforehand to walk into a world of obscurantism and petty vexations. Those 'Gentlemen of the Bedchamber' from the *Mémoires de Collé* peopled the vision which promptly flashed across my mind.

Among the benches which fill the pit, every seat is numbered, and *rows one to eleven* are reserved unconditionally for the military—Officers of the *Red Guards*, of the *Blue Guards*, of the *Guards of the Gateway*, etc., etc.—or else are distributed by special favour amongst the *élite* of permanent subscribers; in consequence of which, the unhappy foreigner newly-arrived in the city finds himself relegated to the twelfth row. Add to this already considerable distance from the stage the vast area occupied by the orchestra, and you will realise that the unlucky tourist is mercilessly driven well back into the remoter half of the auditorium, and installed willy-nilly in a position whence he can neither see the stage nor hear the singers. No such

monstrous system prevails in Milan: at *la Scala*, first come, first served is the rule for every seat. In the fair and fortunate city of Milan, every man may know himself equal of his neighbour; but in Naples, the meanest threadbare *Duke* without a thousand crowns a year to bolster up his pretensions, may invoke the prestige of the best part of a dozen *stars* and *garters* to jab his insolent elbows in my ribs. By contrast, in Milan, an honest citizen with two or three millions to his name will courteously stand aside to let me pass, should I show signs of being in a hurry, expecting me to do the same for him should need arise; and you may study in vain to recognise the bearers of many a famous name, so simple is their aspect and so modest their demeanour. Tonight, exasperated by the insolence of the *gend'armes*, I abandoned the pit and made my way towards my box; and even then, as I climbed the staircase, my temper was scarcely improved by encountering, in descending phalanx, a dozen or fifteen star-spangled Lord-High-Whatnots and Generals, ambling majestically downwards beneath the accumulated weight and grandeur of their mightiness, their braided jackets and their monumental noses. I reflected upon the inscrutable necessity of all this rag-bag of hereditary nobility, stars, privilege, garters and insolence, without which mere *courage* could never be dreamed of in an army.

The final scene of Duport's ballet shows the apotheosis of Cinderella: she stands alone in the dark depths of a forest; then a back-cloth is lowered, and the audience beholds a wondrous palace riding high upon a hill-top, the summit of which is illuminated by the magical light of those incandescent white projectors, whose use is more or less understood at *la Scala*, but whose possibilities are far more effectively exploited here in Naples. As I sought to leave the theatre, I found the staircase blocked by a seething mass of people. To reach the exit, there are three steep flights of stairs to be negotiated, with each man crushed hard upon his neighbour's heels. The Neapolitans

refer to this as one of the 'beauties' of the place. They have built the pit of their theatre a floor above the ground; this, in terms of modern architecture, is what is described as an 'ingenious improvement'; which means that, since there is but one general staircase to accommodate some two or three thousand spectators, and since this staircase is always cluttered up in any case with a host of footmen and bootblacks, the pleasures of this forced descent may best be left to the reader's own imagination.

To sum it up, then: the *San-Carlo* is a masterpiece of operatic architecture, provided that the curtain remains *down*! I feel in no wise inclined to eat my original words: the first sight of this theatre is indeed overwhelming; but as soon as the curtain goes up, then disappointment follows disappointment, each hard upon the heels of the last. Do you wish to sit in the pit? Then our friends the *gend'armes* will see you safe installed a dozen rows from the front, whence you cannot hear a note, nor yet so much as make out with your eyes whether the actor, whose frantic gestures you dimly perceive upon the distant stage, is young or old.¹ Do you decide to return to your box upstairs? Alas! this self-same dazzling, blinding light pursues you even here. Would you attempt to shut your ears against la Colbran's piercing ululations, by reading the paper until such time as the ballet shall begin? Impossible! Your box has no concealing curtains. Are you suffering from a cold, making it advisable to keep your hat upon your head? Inconceivable! The theatre is being *honoured* by the *presence* of Prince ***. Would you then take refuge in the coffee-house attached to the theatre? Poor comfort—it is nothing but a narrow and lugubrious corridor, of loathsome aspect. Or in the *foyer*? The staircase by which you must pass is so steep and so damnably awkward that, when you reach your goal at last, the breath is quite gone from your body.

¹ At such a distance, all the genius of Madame Pasta would be completely lost. [1826]

21st March. This morning, I felt the fever of ambition upon me—a melancholy, atrabilious distemper which haunts me these two years. The ills of the mind, I knew from the Sages of the Orient, must be cured by the medicine of the body. I took a boat, therefore, and sailed four hours upon the sea; and landed finally at Ischia, armed with a letter of recommendation to don Fernando.

It was in the year 1806 (so he told me) that he had taken refuge in Ischia; nor had he once set eyes upon the city of Naples since the day the French, whom he abhors, usurped the dominion of the land. Ischia has no theatre; so, to console himself, he breeds vast quantities of nightingales in wondrous aviaries.

‘Music’, he argued, ‘is an art which has no model in the natural universe, other than the song of birds; and, like the song of birds, music is a series of *interjections*. Now, an interjection is a cry of emotion, never an expression of thought. Thought may *produce* emotion; but the interjection itself is never anything but emotion pure and simple. Consequently, music is, of its very nature, incapable of expressing the dry and logical concepts of thought. Sometimes’, added this most sensitive of *dilettanti*, ‘my skylarks, singing in the morning, give voice to a strange *falsetto* note which reminds me of Marchesi and Pacchiarotti.’

I spent today four delightful hours in the company of don Fernando (who abominates all things French) and of the worthy islanders of Ischia. These islanders are pure African savages . . . good-natured simplicity of their dialect . . . they live off the produce of their vineyards. Scarcely a trace of civilisation—no small advantage, this, when ‘civilisation’ means wholly Popery and all its ritual. In Naples, a man of the people will inform you coldly: ‘A year since, come August, there was a misfortune that I had’, which, being translated into plainer language, means simply: ‘In August last year, I murdered a man.’ Yet, should you propose that he should accompany you up Vesuvius

next Sunday, leaving at three o'clock in the morning, he will recoil in pious horror, exclaiming: 'Faith, I? And miss the Holy Mass?'

Ritual may be learnt by heart; but as soon as you admit the doctrine of *good works*, then such works may be good to a greater or lesser degree; hence it is but a step to an *Examination of Conscience*, and so, by relentless progression, on to the tenets of *Protestantism* and ultimately to the reckless merriment of an *English Methodist*.

22nd March. I am truly distressed that I may not describe the delights of the ball given by Mr Lewis, author of *The Monk*, at the lodgings of Mrs Lushington, his sister. Amid the gross and philistine patterns of Neapolitan behaviour, the frank and upright moral character of England is a refreshing experience. When I danced an *écossaise*, I observed, among the other dancers, young Lord Chichester, but fourteen years of age and a plain midshipman aboard the frigate which dropped anchor yesterday in the roads. The English understand the miraculous effects of education—and as I read it, they are likely to need all the miracles they can muster, for I observed plainly in the faces of one or two Americans present that, thirty years from now, England will possess nothing in all the world, save her own happiness. Lord N[orth] agreed with me.

'Every nation in the world', I argued, 'detests the very name of England; yet this hatred is particularly violent among the rabble and the lower elements. Educated people draw a sharp distinction between Lord Grosvenor, Lord Holland—indeed, the bulk of the nation—and the present Ministry.'

'For all that', replied Lord N[orth], 'granted even that this general hatred among the nations were a score of times less temperate than it is, yet every state in Europe for a hundred years to come is destined to live through a mortal sickness, a revolutionary indigestion springing from its desperate resolve

to win a constitution; and none can hope to command a Navy before the twentieth century.'

'Agreed', I answered, 'but the *Americans* detest you also, and will be lying in wait for you twenty years hence, armed with a commerce-raiding fleet five hundred strong. You are beginning to realise already—is it not true?—that France is no longer the "hereditary foe"; the escape of M. de Lavalette, followed by the *Loan**, has begun the work of reconciliation. So why not be generous with us?'¹

Among the many biting epigrams, which I, as a Frenchman, was forced to swallow, the following in particular struck home:

'In some countries, when a score of persons are gathered together in one place to speak evil of the government, this is known as a *conspiracy*.'

One or two details that I have observed suggest to me that the art of conspiracy might well be better understood in Naples: here men at least would *act* instead of talking. This realm is destined without fail to achieve a bicameral government within the next two decades; despotism may crush the nation ten times running, and yet the nation will revolt an eleventh time against the despot. The present *régime*, with its obsessive resolve to put the clock back, is humiliating to the pride of the aristocracy.

Lord N[orth], one of the most enlightened men in England, agreed with me, albeit with a sigh.

(I caught sight once again of my beautiful *contessa*, who is wont to journey to Terracina to visit her lover. For sheer loveliness—the facts brook no denial—the women of Albion outdistance all their rivals: Lady Douglas, Lady Lansdowne.)

23rd March. A night of masked balls. I began the evening at *la Fenice*; later on, at half an hour past midnight I moved

¹ In the town of Troyes, in 1815, a party of Englishmen chanced to remark the well-appointed factory set up by M. Taissaire. Two days later, an Allied regiment appeared upon the scene, and smashed every loom in the shops. [1817]

across to the *San-Carlo*. I had looked to find a night of dazzling splendour—nothing of the sort. The stage of the theatre, transformed into a ball-room, enjoyed none of that lush magnificence which the scene-painters of *la Scala* are wont to lavish on such gala occasions; instead, all the decoration consisted of a plain white back-drop studded with huge *fleurs-de-lis* in gold leaf. Tickets can be had for as little as six *carlins* (about 2 fr. 50). The lowest brand of company imaginable—yet, in the *foyer*, where there were a score of gaming-tables stacked with gold, a gentleman might happen upon more suitable acquaintance. I derived great entertainment watching a certain lovely creature playing *faro*—a *duchessa* with whom I danced once, on the occasion of the party at the Royal Palace. Her chair stood some four paces from the tables; the task of placing and withdrawing her stakes was delegated to her lover; her own fair features showed not a trace of that hideous intoxication which stamps the face of the true gambler. The lover in question had been discussing art with me only a day or two before, and had talked to me of Paris. ‘In Paris’, he observed, ‘no man alive will make a single gesture, unless it bear the stamp of *breeding*—in other words, of *imitation*; consequently, the art of painting is impossible in France. Genius in France, with the solitary exception of La Fontaine, is *sophisticated*; the least sophisticated artist can boast of no more genuine *naïveté* than can some pert but impoverished young lady of eighteen, who has already mismanaged three prospective wealthy marriages.’

24th March. The Countess of R***, that fair flower of Scotland, remarked to me this evening: ‘Your compatriots, who are so irresistible during the first few hours of an acquaintance, have not the slightest notion how to inspire a truly *profound* passion. At first meeting, it must suffice to awaken curiosity; but your glittering, don-Juanesque Frenchman, who creates so dazzling an impression during the first instants, and thereafter loses

ground progressively, can reign no more than for a fleeting moment over a woman's heart.'

'Here precisely', I rejoined, 'is the secret which explains the icy indifference with which I am about to bid farewell to the *San-Carlo*.'

Whereupon a Neapolitan prince, chancing to be present during this exchange, began to protest most energetically, and proceeded to refute our objections in the true manner of Italy—i.e., by restating over and over again, on each occasion in more strident tones, the original claim to which objection had been made. I was busily engaged in staring about the room, hoping thus to bring his diatribe to a close for want of listeners to appreciate it, when I grew aware that he was insistently reiterating the outlandish word *Agadaneca*. This, apparently, is an opera of unimaginable splendour, which, encouraged by powerful ministerial patronage and dedicated in advance to His Majesty, has already been in rehearsal for some five months. 'At last', asserts the voice of public opinion, 'we shall behold an opera not unworthy of the *San-Carlo*.'

SALERNO, 1st April. Should you be curious to make first-hand acquaintance with the most degrading moral picture in the world, then I recommend that you should take a random peep behind the scenes at family life in Calabria . . . incredible, the tales that I was told this morning! While I was in Bologna, I was reading the works of the *original* mediaeval historians, Capponi, Villani, Fiortifiocca, etc. Scarcely a page but contained anecdotes such as that of the massacre of Cesena by the Anti-Pope Clement VII.¹ And yet, when all is said and done, the imagination is left with a feeling of respect, or even of friendship, towards these colossal figures, the Castrucci, the Guglielmini, the Counts of Virtù*. There is no trace of such atrocities in the chronicles of the eighteenth century—so little,

¹ Poggii, *Hist.*, lib. II, *la Cronaca sanese*: 'E il Cardinale disse a messer Giovanni . . .' etc., etc. [1817]

indeed, that, in the long run, the reader must grow sick at heart from sheer contempt.¹ Yet the Calabrians—these I cannot despise, for all that they are *barbarians*, who profess an indivisible belief in Hell, indulgences and the *jettatura* (spell cast by a sorcerer).

2nd April. The strangest sight I saw in all my wanderings has been Pompei. Here, the traveller may feel himself transported bodily into the realms of antiquity; and he whose mind is trained, however ill, to believe nought but what is plain and proven, may discover in a flash more solid truth than the most ingenious of scholars. There is indescribable pleasure to be had from meeting face to face with this self-same antiquity, concerning which one has read such countless volumes. Today, I visited Pompei for the eleventh time; yet this is not the place to tell of what I saw. Two theatres have been excavated, together with a third at Herculaneum; all so intact as scarcely to deserve the name of ruins. I wholly fail to see the need for that curious, *mystical* tone which Herr Schlegel has felt called upon to adopt in his recent treatises upon the antique theatre; yet I was forgetting that Herr Schlegel is a *German*, whereas I, apparently, *I*, ungifted Frenchman that I am, have no deep *innere Stimmung* concerning the meaning of the world. Our world having begun with the republics of antiquity, it is not wholly surprising to discover that the heroes of this epoch should seem such god-like creatures to later generations, whose souls—as in the case of Racine—are blanched to atrophy by the insipidity of kings and courtiers.

I have just been to see *Saül* at the *teatro Nuovo*. I can only suppose that this tragedy (by Alfieri) touches some hidden spring in the subconscious national character of Italian audiences; at all events, it stirs them to wild outbursts of enthusiasm. In *Michal*, the daughter of Saul, they discover all the

¹ Lacretelle, Duclos, Bezenval, Saint-Simon, Rulhière, the Prince de Ligne, Mackintosh, Belsham, Hobhouse. [1817]

tender charms of *Imogen*. Yet I, for some reason, found myself impervious to all these qualities—so impervious, indeed, that I spent most of the evening in conversation with that young *marchese* of liberal sympathies who had lent me his box. Beside us, there sat a young girl, whose eyes, shining with all the joy and tenderness of love, flashed with a darting energy of passion, the like of which I never saw before. Three hours sped by us, swift as lightning. Next to her sat her betrothed, and her mother, relaxing her customary severity, allowed him to kiss his mistress' hand.

My *marchese* informed me that, here in Naples, only three of Alfieri's tragedies are permitted on the stage; in Rome, four; in Bologna, five; in Milan, seven; and in Turin, none at all. Consequent upon this censorship, applause becomes tantamount to waving a banner, whereas criticism is the stamp of a black obscurantist.

As a dramatist, Alfieri suffered from the absence of a wide enough audience. The groundlings are as vital to a genius as troops are to a general. Alfieri was fated to rage and fret against the tyranny of prejudice, only to finish by acknowledging his own surrender. Politically, and to the bitter end, his mind refused to grasp the incalculable benefits of a revolution which was destined to bestow, upon Europe and America alike, the advantages of parliamentary government, and to *make a clean sweep* of all the old abuses. Among the major poets of the world, Alfieri was perhaps second to none for the tempest of feeling which raged within him; but, in the first place, he never knew but *one* emotion; and in the second, his political viewpoint was always excessively narrow. He never grasped the elementary truth (see the concluding chapters of his *Autobiography*¹) that no revolution can succeed without the

¹ *Vita di Vittorio Alfieri, da Asti, scritta da esso*. . . . The reader should consult the original edition; the translation was badly chopped about by *Buonaparte's* police-censorship. Alfieri offers the typical portrait of every generous and noble spirit in Italy at the present juncture: more fury than intelligence. [1817]

creation of a new economic interest, *i.e.*, a new property-owning *élite*. To begin with, his mind never ran along those lines; while furthermore, he was an aristocrat, and a Piedmontese into the bargain.¹ The insolence of minor officialdom demanding his passport at the *barrière de Pantin**, together with the theft of some twelve or fifteen hundred volumes from his library, sowed seeds of rancour within his heart, which, falling in the fertile soil of his own aristocratical prejudices, decreed that he should forever fail to master the pure mechanics of liberty. This noblest of intellects never managed to realise that, in the field of politics, the *sine qua non* of tolerable writing is a careful act of *dissociation* from all the rubs and trifling personal vexations that the philosopher himself may have suffered in the course of his existence. In the closing phase of his life, he used to say that genius was the exclusive privilege of a *gentleman*; and when all was said and done, he, whose contempt for French literature verged close upon obsessive hatred, could offer nothing more than a grotesque exaggeration of the narrow conventions of Racine. To the Italian mind, it would be hard to conceive anything more consummately absurd than the cowardice of a *Britannicus* or the preciousity of a *Bajazet*. The average Italian, pursued night and day by the demon of mistrust, demands to *see*—and is constantly fobbed off with second-hand accounts. His vagabond fancy must perpetually be nourished by the visible splendour of action; otherwise his imagination rises up in passionate revolt, and bears him off to more fruitful regions. It is logical enough, therefore, to find that Alfieri's tragedies are greeted by many a smothered yawn. To date, I have discovered nothing better fitted to the temperament of Italy than *Richard III*, *Othello* or *Romeo and Juliet*.

¹ He never learned to appreciate the generosity of the Princes of the august House of Savoy. Sovereigns of the stamp of those who presently occupy the various thrones of Naples, Florence and Sardinia seem purposely to have been designed by nature to bring about a reconciliation between the monarchic principle and those whom pride has seduced into the wildest of excesses. [1817]

Signor Niccolini, current heir to the dramatic traditions of Alfieri, is headed off on a false scent. *Cf. Ino e Temisto.*

3rd April. *Agadaneca*, 'Grand Opera' . . . never in all my life have I heard so much perilous rubbish decked out in so much pretentious clap-trap; its 'two-hours' traffic' spanned moderately from seven in the evening until half an hour past midnight, without a single instant's pause for breath, and without the first faint sigh of melody in the music. I could almost have thought myself at home in the *rue Lepeletier*. Long live opera under Royal patronage! The master-stroke of the evening was a scene in *Fingal's Cave* (for we are plunged deep in the realms of Ossian!), luxuriously appointed with all the latest knick-knacks straight from Paris. As a favour, I was granted permission to visit the stage. All the poor little creatures from the ballet-school were moaning and lamenting: 'Five months' rehearsal, and all for a flop like *that*!' I murmured a word or two of polite sympathy to signorina Colbran: 'Indeed, sir', she replied, 'the audience is more than generous; I was fully prepared for them to tear up the very benches from the pit, and hurl them at our heads!' I now realise, in fact, that the librettists, to whom, previously, I had attributed nothing worse than *banality*, are chronic *imbeciles* as well. Signorina Colbran showed me their *Solemn Dedication to His Majesty*, printed at the head of the libretto. It is their unassuming intention (so they claim) to 'revive the solemn awe and splendour of Greek Tragedy.' . . .!

The music of Act III—a sort of ballet in the form of a Pyrrhic dance—is by Gallenberg. Graf Wenzel von Gallenberg is a German who has settled in Naples and who has a special genius for composing ballet-music: this evening's sample was worthless; but I have listened to passages from *Cesare in Egitto* and from *il Cavaliere dei Templari*, where the music doubly intensifies that state of indescribable intoxication produced by the dancing. Ideally, music which is destined for the ballet

should have all the lightness of a brilliant sketch, in which *rhythm* assumes an unusual significance; it offers no field for that sort of complex orchestral scoring of which Haydn is such a master; but there is great scope for passages scored for the horn. The scene in *Cesare in Egitto*, where Caesar is allowed to cross the threshold of Cleopatra's bed-chamber, is scored in a style fit to incarnate the Houris of Mohammed himself. Not even the sighing and voluptuous genius of Tasso would have disowned the instant when the ghostly *Shade* appears before the affrighted eyes of the *Knight Templar*; for he, all unbeknownst, has slain his mistress; and now, wandering uncertainly after nightfall deep in some trackless forest of the Holy Land, chances to pass close beside the tomb where she lies buried; whereupon her spirit rises up before him, points heavenward in answer to his grief and questioning anguish, and melts into the immaterial air. The pale and noble countenance of la Bianchi, the tortured expression of Molinari, the sighing notes of Gallenberg's music—all these formed a scene whose memory will never fade within the recesses of my soul.

4th April. A visit to the *teatro Nuovo*. The de' Marini company was giving its one hundred and ninety-seventh performance. Vestris, for all his stoutness, is the finest actor in Italy—indeed, in all the world; in *il Burbero benefico*, as in *l'Ajo nell'imbarazzo*, not to mention that host of worthless rhapsodies to which he alone gives shape and meaning, his skill is equal to that of Molé and Iffland. His performance will bear watching twenty times in succession without the slightest fear of boredom. If Mademoiselle Mars should be cast for the part of some dizzy or bird-witted flibbertigibbet, the slyest of secret glances, irresistibly seductive to the private vanity of the audience, will betray the fact that none is more sensitive than herself to the absurdity of her rôle, or to the idiocy of the gestures that she will presently allow herself to perform. This is a serious flaw, of which neither Vestris nor Madame Pasta is ever guilty.

In the eyes of Italian audiences (and more especially the feminine section thereof), none holds a higher place in the hierarchy than de' Marini, whose skill I have been admiring this evening in *li Baroni di Felsheim* (the translation of a play by Pigault-Lebrun) and in *i due Paggi*. In Italy, for a variety of reasons not wholly unknown to myself, natural simplicity is distinctly out of favour on the printed page; the average Italian must have his literature tricked out with all manner of high-flown and bombastic rhetoric. Our present fashion—those fulsome *Encomiums* by Antoine Thomas, *le Génie du Christianisme*, *la Gaule poétique*, and all the lush, poetical bag of tricks which, for ten years now, have made us the *envy of the civilised world*—such stuff would seem specifically devised to match the taste of Italy. The unpretentious prose of a Voltaire, a Hamilton or a Montesquieu leaves Italian readers patently unmoved. Here you have the principle which explains and underlies the boundless reputation of de' Marini. He fashions his art upon nature, yet distantly; indeed, nature may hardly be held to challenge the divine prerogative of *Rhetoric* within his heart. In days gone by, he was wont to steal away the very soul of Italy in his various *jeune premier rôles*; nowadays, he has turned to *Noble Father* parts; and since such parts admit a fair degree of bombast, I have often found entertainment watching his performance.

Naïveté is a virtue seldom met with in the Italian theatre; yet no Italian can tolerate *la Nouvelle Héloïse*. Such rare traces of *naïveté* as I have ever discovered dwell in the breast of signorina Marchioni, a young actress of desperately emotional temperament, who appears on the stage at least once, sometimes twice a day, beginning at four o'clock with an open-air *matinée* for the populace, and giving a second performance later, at eight o'clock, under the artificial glare of battens and footlights, for the gentry. Today I watched her twice—at four o'clock in *la Gazza Ladra*, and at eight o'clock in *Francesca da Rimini*—and on both occasions, she held me enthralled to the very brink of ecstasy. There is an actress in the de' Marini company,

signora Tassari, who is not at all bad in parts of a similar character. Her husband, Tassari, is a first-class 'heavy', specialising in *Tyrants*.

Blanès, in the days before he went off and married a fortune, used to be the Talma of Italy. He was lacking neither in power nor in the gift of naturalism: as *Almachilde* in Alfieri's *Rosmunda*, he was the very incarnation of *terror*. In the same play, the title-rôle (poor Queen, unhappy victim of such tempestuous passions!) was played by signora Pelandi, whom I have never found anything but wearisome, but who, none the less, won herself a tempest of applause.

Pertica, whom I saw tonight, is a competent comic actor, more especially in heavy character parts. I found him boring beyond words in *il Poeta fanatico*, one of the dreariest plays ever perpetrated by Goldoni, yet one which is seldom long out of the repertoire. This may be realism, I grant you—yet how unspeakably *vulgar*! Besides which (as though this were not already sin enough!), it excites the contempt and derision of the brutal mob by dragging through the mud before its eyes that noblest work of nature: a great poet. Pertica was thunderously applauded in the part of *Brandt*, and indeed deserved his triumph, particularly in the final scene, when he speaks the line to Frederick II: '*I shall write you a letter.*'

But that which struck me most forcibly of all was the audience itself. I never beheld a sterner concentration, nor yet (miracle of miracles in this fair city of Naples!) a stiller silence. This morning, by eight o'clock, every seat in the house was sold; to get a ticket, I was forced to pay three times the proper price.

Backstairs patriotism, that besetting sin of Italy, admits, in my experience, two isolated exceptions: the readiness with which the average Italian audience will allow the superiority of French ballet; and the childish curiosity with which this same audience will open its mouth and swallow, whole and undigested, every tit-bit of drooling sentimentality ever translated from the German theatre.

To clap at French ballet implies that he who claps has been to Paris. The emotional responsiveness of Italy is so profound and so genuine, while reading is so rare an occupation, that nothing—not even the silliest of dramatised novelettes, provided only that it be bristling with incident and action—is too insipid to excite the unfailing compassion of these virgin sensibilities. For thirty years, not a single sentimental novel has seen the light of day in Italy. The logical deduction from this fact would seem to be, that when a man is exclusively pre-occupied with a single passion, no *portrait* of that passion, be it never so alluring, can leave him anything but stonily indifferent. The literary periodical is unknown in Italy. Bertolotti, that ingenious intellect, author of *Ines di Castro*, used to say to me: ‘First furnish me with a castle-keep for refuge: *then* will I dare to speak a few home truths to the writers of Italy!’

Tonight’s curtain-raiser consisted of a little comedy by Mercier, *la Jeunesse de Henri V*, in Duval’s adapted version*. Pertica drew great bursts of laughter out of Prince don Leopold, who was present among the audience; but, dear God in Heaven! what dragging, desperate efforts he must make, compared with Michaut at the *Théâtre Français*! My nearest neighbour tonight turned out to be an Italian priest, who professed himself utterly bewildered by the success this play had had in Paris: ‘Words!’ he muttered. ‘All you ever want is *words*! You never reach beyond, never grasp at the *character* underneath.’ Count Giraùd, the Beaumarchais of Italy, has written two or three pretty comedies, including *l’Ajo nell’ imbarazzo* and *il Disperato per eccesso di buon core*. Others—Nota, the lawyer, Sografi, Federici—are forever veering towards the abysses of melodrama, and even their truly comical comedies are designed to appeal to a society far less cultured than our own. In this matter of sophistication, Picard is as far in advance of Goldoni as Molière is in advance of Picard. In the dramatic world of Goldoni, whenever a householder has guests for dinner, it is taken for granted that he must send out to borrow a set of

cutlery for six, the family silver being presently in pawn. It must not be forgotten, however, that Goldoni was writing in Venice; and that the Venetian aristocracy would soon enough have furnished him with a cell (or coffin) in the *Leads*, had he proved rash enough to display a faithful portrait of *their* style of living before the eyes of their unhappy subjects. Consequently, Goldoni was obliged to confine his talent to the portrayal of dregs and outcasts, whose manners are so crude and so uncouth, that no others may fittingly serve for comparison. I find myself unable to laugh at their expense. As a dramatist, Goldoni was faithful as a mirror to the times in which he lived; yet he lacked even the dullest gleam of intelligence. Falstaff is the biggest coward the world ever saw; yet despite his cowardice (which is nothing less than astounding), he keeps his wits so razor-sharp about him that I am unable to feel contempt: he is an object worthy of my laughter. Falstaff rings truer still when he struts the boards before a morose and melancholy people who tremble at the very name of that relentless *Duty* whose voice the fat Knight so unfailingly disobeys. Suppose that Italy, in alliance with Hungary, should one day wrest the privilege of parliamentary government from the powers which hold her still in thrall: then, from that day forward, she will have neither time nor thought to spare for art. Aye, there's the rub—which Alfieri and all the rout of ranting phrasemongers after him quite failed to foresee. If ever Italy evolves a comic style of her own, it will have the *colour* of Fabre d'Eglantine's *Philinte* and the *grace* of Act IV of Shakespeare's *Merchant of Venice*: which quality, by the way, has no connection with the like-named virtue in Saint-Foix' comedy *les Grâces*.

5th April. I have just ridden thirty miles, and all to no purpose. Caserta is no better than a barracks set in a landscape as unpromising as that of Versailles. Because of the danger of earthquakes, all the walls of the palace are built five foot thick; in consequence—as at St Peter's—the apartments stay warm in

winter and cool in summer. Murat attempted to complete this edifice: the paintings which adorn it are even drearier than those of Paris, but the general scheme of decoration is more grandiose.

To console my disappointed heart, I set off post-haste upon my return for Portici and Capo di Monte—elevations so enchanting that no Prince in all the earth may find the like. Nowhere under Heaven may the eye discover so wondrous a prospect of mountain, sea and civilisation. The traveller stands amidst the noblest manifestations of nature; yet, with all that, may, within a space of five-and-thirty minutes, sit listening to *il Matrimonio segreto*, sung by Davide and Lablache. Granting even that Naples may have rivals for natural beauty in Constantinople or Rio de Janeiro, yet can either city hope to emulate her in this? The citizens of Montreal or Torneaa are worthy folk, I allow; yet how should they ever conceive the notion of a fair Neapolitan, whose beauty is tempered by an implacable intelligence worthy of Voltaire? Such bewitching creatures are rarer even than a prospect of mountains or the entrancing panorama of a bay. Yet, were I to speak at greater length concerning signora C***, I should succeed in nothing save in goading the reader into a wry outbreak of laughter, whether from envy or from disbelief. Portici is to Naples what Monte Cavallo is to Rome. The average Italian is fully persuaded that we from the North are nothing better than barbarians in all matters relating to the arts—a conviction which is not merely ineradicable, but openly asserted on every possible occasion. Yet this same Italian is constantly agape with admiration at the originality and elegance of our *furniture*.

As I was leaving the *Museum of Antique Painting* at Portici, I met with a trio of English naval officers, who were on their way in. Now, this Museum contains no less than two-and-twenty rooms. On the road back into Naples, I kept up a steady gallop; yet before I reached the *ponte della Maddalena*, I was caught and overtaken by these same three English travellers, who, later in the evening, assured me that the paintings they

had seen were positively *splendid*, and indeed one of the strangest sights in all the universe. The total time which they had spent inside the Museum amounted to somewhere between three and four minutes.

This collection, which affords such a treasure-house of curiosities for the true lover of art, consists of frescoes which have been removed from Pompei and Herculaneum. They reveal a complete absence of *chiaroscuro*, a very limited range of colour, a passable feeling for design and considerable facility. Two items in particular I found pleasing: *Orestes recognised by Iphigenia in the Island of Tauris*, and *Theseus thanked by the young Athenians for having delivered them from the Minotaur*. Both contain a wealth of noble simplicity, without a single theatrical gesture. The general impression is of a series of bad works by Domenichino, albeit further still removed from greatness by the presence of numerous faults of draughtsmanship—errors which this fine artist would never have committed. There are to be observed at Portici, among a host of minor, half-obliterated frescoes, five or six major productions on the scale of Raphael's *Santa Cecilia*. Once upon a time, these frescoes served to ornament a bath-chamber at Herculaneum. Yet no one save a scholar could be so asinine as to claim that such stuff outweighs the *quattrocento*; in point of fact, it is nothing but a highly-remarkable artistic curio; it serves to prove the existence *elsewhere* of a finely-developed style, much as those 'artistic wallpapers' manufactured in Mâcon serve to prove the existence of a painter such as David.

6th April. The *Giornale di Napoli* has taken up the cudgels on behalf of the *teatro San-Carlo* against the *Gazzetta di Genova*. I am firmly persuaded that every god and goddess in the whole of mythology, together with every Latin poet whose works are handed down to us, is invoked or quoted in this article, whose success has been phenomenal. In all other respects it is, from beginning to end, a tissue of shameless lies.

I am almost tempted to transcribe it *in toto*, simply to punish those among my readers (assuming such ignominious creatures to exist) who still refuse to grant unquestioning credence to all my anecdotes, and to the moral consequences which I draw therefrom.

Arbuthnot's *Martinus Scriblerus* is forgotten in London, as indeed is any satirist who has slain the *Monster* which he attacked. *Martinus Scriblerus* dates from 1741. Italy today (1817) is precisely ripe for such a satire.

The *abate* Taddei (editor of the *Giornale delle due Sicilie*) is infinitely more absurd than our learned friends MM. G*** and M*** in Paris*: but he is not *detested*, as they are. The Austrian commandant has forbidden him to designate anyone as a *bad citizen*. The honest Teutonic common-sense of these worthy Austrians has—on this occasion at least—prevented untold bloodshed in Naples.

7th April. Another evening with the de' Marini company. Their wardrobe is resplendent: all the cast-off finery of Napoleonic *senators* and *chamberlains*, which the sometime holders of these offices have been cowardly enough to sell. Half the success of the company may be traced directly to these costumes; my neighbours on every hand were gasping with admiration. I find myself entrusted with the strangest secrets. As things stand in Italy today, the strongest recommendation which any man may bear is to be French and to hold no official post of any kind.

Towards midnight, I proceeded to take tea with a party of Greek students, who are here to study medicine. If I had had the time, I would have left then and there for Corfù, where, as I suspect, the rigours of opposition put steel into the souls of men.

The factors which are essential if art is to flourish are often diametrically opposed to those which are indispensable if a nation is to be happy. Moreover, these factors can never

exercise any *lasting* influence, for art demands a wealth of leisure, together with unbounded depths of passion; yet leisure leads inevitably to sophistication, while sophistication, no less inevitably, destroys the depths of passion. Logically, therefore, it is impossible to engender a nation of artists. No man with a spark of generosity in his nature but is racked with longing to see the resurgence of Greece; but what must fatally emerge from such a struggle is not the century of Pericles, but rather something resembling the United States of America. We are moving towards an era of universal suffrage; and universal suffrage, being wholly concerned with *government*, will have no leisure to dwell with impassioned fervour upon the subtleties of art. Yet what matter? Liberty is the necessity of necessities, while art is merely a *luxury*, whose lack can be endured without distress.

PAESTUM, 30th April. Any commentary upon the architecture of the temples at Paestum would require too long an exposition, and would involve concepts too hard to understand. My companion in the course of this excursion—a charming young man by the name of T***, who can point to relatives in both opposing parties, and who, in 1799, when the revolution broke out in Naples, was but fifteen years of age—has today related to me the following strange occurrence.

‘In Naples, the sceptre of state was wielded by a woman of genius. Originally an enthusiastic partisan of the French Revolution (this, out of jealousy directed against a *Certain Person*), she soon came to realise the danger which threatened every throne in Europe, and took up arms against it with impassioned fury. *Were I not Queen of Naples*, she observed on one occasion, *I could dearly wish to be Robespierre*. And indeed, in one of the Royal Boudoirs there was to be seen a gigantic painting representing that fatal instrument by which her sister had perished*.